Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

أُذِنَ لِلَّذِينَ يُقَاتَلُونَ بِأَنَّهُمْ ظُلِمُوا

"Permission has been given to those who are fought against, because they were wronged." (al-Ḥajj 22:39)

The Battles of the Prophet ﷺ

The maghāzī of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ, from the first expeditions and Badr to the Opening of Makkah, Ḥunayn and Tabūk.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

For thirteen years in Makkah, the Prophet ﷺ and his Companions were mocked, beaten, boycotted and tortured, and some were killed. Through all of it they were commanded to be patient and not to fight back. Then came the Hijrah, a small Muslim community in Madinah, and enemies who would not leave it in peace. Allah gave permission to fight, and in the ten years that followed, the Prophet ﷺ led or sent dozens of expeditions. By the end of them, idolatry had been cleared from the Kaʿbah and almost all of Arabia had entered Islām.

These campaigns are called the **maghāzī**. The early Muslims gave them great importance. ʿAlī ibn al-Ḥusayn (Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn), the great-grandson of the Prophet ﷺ, said: "We used to be taught the maghāzī of the Prophet ﷺ as we were taught a sūrah of the Qur'an." And Ismāʿīl, the grandson of Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ, said that his father used to teach them the maghāzī and say: "These are the honour of your forefathers, so do not neglect their memory."

> لَقَدْ كَانَ لَكُمْ فِي رَسُولِ اللَّهِ أُسْوَةٌ حَسَنَةٌ لِّمَن كَانَ يَرْجُو اللَّهَ وَالْيَوْمَ الْآخِرَ وَذَكَرَ اللَّهَ كَثِيرًا
>
> **"There has certainly been for you in the Messenger of Allah an excellent example, for whoever hopes in Allah and the Last Day and remembers Allah often."**
>
> Al-Aḥzāb 33:21, revealed about the Battle of the Trench.

This verse was revealed in the middle of a siege, about how the Prophet ﷺ behaved when the enemy surrounded Madinah. The battles show the Prophet ﷺ as a leader, a commander, a teacher and a man of mercy, in hunger and in victory, in defeat and in triumph. That is why we study them: not to glorify war, but to learn faith, patience, obedience, courage and justice from the best of people.

How this book tells the story

The events here are taken first from the **Qur'an**, which describes many of the battles directly, then from the **authentic ḥadīth**, above all the Book of Maghāzī in Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī and the Book of Jihād and Expeditions in Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim. The source is given each time.

The details of the battles (numbers, routes, some names and speeches) come mostly from the **books of sīrah**: Ibn Isḥāq (through Ibn Hishām), Mūsā ibn ʿUqbah, Ibn Saʿd and later scholars such as Ibn Kathīr and Ibn al-Qayyim. The scholars accepted these for history, but not every report in them is authentic. When something is reported only in the sīrah, this book says so ("it is reported", "the sīrah books say").

Numbers in the sīrah are approximate, and dates are sometimes disputed. Where the scholars differ, the best-known view is given and the difference is noted.

Contents

01 **Understanding the maghāzī**
Key words, why the Prophet ﷺ fought, the rules of war, a map and a timeline

02 **Badr: the Day of Criterion (1–2 AH)**
The first expeditions, Badr in depth, and Banū Qaynuqāʿ

03 **Uḥud and its trials (3–4 AH)**
Uḥud, Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad, ar-Rajīʿ, Biʾr Maʿūnah, Banū an-Naḍīr, Dhāt ar-Riqāʿ

04 **The Trench and the Truce (5–6 AH)**
Banū al-Muṣṭaliq, al-Khandaq, Banū Qurayẓah, Dhū Qarad, al-Ḥudaybiyah

05 **The Opening (7–8 AH)**
Khaybar, ʿUmrat al-Qaḍāʾ, Muʾtah and the Opening of Makkah

06 **Ḥunayn, aṭ-Ṭāʾif and Tabūk (8–9 AH)**
The last battles, the Anṣār, Kaʿb ibn Mālik, and the end of the maghāzī

07 **All the battles at a glance**
The 27 ghazawāt, the major sarāyā, the numbers, and the battles in the Qur'an

08 **The heroes of the battles**
Men and women whose stories every Muslim should know

09 **Jihād rightly understood**
What the battles teach, and what they do not, for Muslims today

10 **Duʿāʾs, lessons, self-test, glossary and reading list**
Fix what you have learned

How to read this book

1	Read **one part at a time**, in order. The battles follow one another, and each explains the next.
2	Keep a **muṣḥaf** beside you. Read the verses mentioned for each battle in the Qur'an itself: al-Anfāl for Badr, Āl ʿImrān for Uḥud, al-Aḥzāb for the Trench, al-Fatḥ for al-Ḥudaybiyah and at-Tawbah for Ḥunayn and Tabūk.
3	Use the **map, timeline and battle plans** to picture where and when things happened.
4	The boxes marked **"For students"** give terms, sources and points of scholarly discussion for older readers.
5	**Teachers and parents:** each battle can be told as a story in one or two sittings, with the "Lessons for us" as the discussion.

Part 1 Understanding the maghāzī

Words to know first

Word	Meaning
Ghazwah (pl. ghazawāt)	An expedition in which the Prophet ﷺ went out himself, whether or not there was fighting.
Sariyyah (pl. sarāyā)	An expedition the Prophet ﷺ sent under one of his Companions, without going himself. Some scholars also call these baʿth.
Maghāzī	The study of all the Prophet's ﷺ expeditions, ghazawāt and sarāyā together.
Jihād fī sabīlillāh	Striving in the path of Allah. In its widest sense it includes striving against oneself and calling to the truth; in fiqh it usually means fighting under the rules Allah has set.
Shahīd (pl. shuhadāʾ)	A martyr: one killed in the path of Allah. The one killed in battle is buried in his clothes, without being washed.
Ghanīmah	Spoils taken in battle, divided by the rules in al-Anfāl 8:41.
Fayʾ	Wealth that comes to the Muslims without fighting, as with Banū an-Naḍīr (al-Ḥashr 59:6–7).
Muʿāhad	A non-Muslim under a treaty or covenant with the Muslims, whose life and property are protected.

Thirteen years of patience

In Makkah, the Muslims were few and weak. Bilāl was dragged over burning sand; Sumayyah, the first martyr of Islām, was killed by Abū Jahl; the family of Yāsir was tortured; the Muslims were boycotted in a valley for about three years until they ate leaves. Some Companions asked the Prophet ﷺ for permission to fight back. They were told to restrain their hands, pray and give zakāh (an-Nisāʾ 4:77). Khabbāb ibn al-Aratt came to the Prophet ﷺ, who was resting in the shade of the Kaʿbah, and asked him to pray for help. The Prophet ﷺ told him how believers before them had been sawn in half without leaving their religion, and said: "By Allah, this matter will be completed… but you are in a hurry" (al-Bukhārī, 3612).

The permission to fight

After the Hijrah, Quraysh did not stop. They had seized the homes and wealth of the Muhājirūn, they threatened the people of Madinah for sheltering them, and they worked to turn the tribes of Arabia against the Muslims. Then the first verses about fighting were revealed. Ibn ʿAbbās and others said this was the first verse revealed about fighting:

أُذِنَ لِلَّذِينَ يُقَاتَلُونَ بِأَنَّهُمْ ظُلِمُوا ۚ وَإِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلَىٰ نَصْرِهِمْ لَقَدِيرٌ ﴿٣٩﴾ الَّذِينَ أُخْرِجُوا مِن دِيَارِهِم بِغَيْرِ حَقٍّ إِلَّا أَن يَقُولُوا رَبُّنَا اللَّهُ

"Permission has been given to those who are fought against, because they were wronged. And indeed, Allah is able to give them victory. Those who were driven out of their homes without right, only because they said: Our Lord is Allah."

Al-Ḥajj 22:39–40.

The same passage gives the wisdom: "Were it not that Allah checks some people by means of others, monasteries, churches, synagogues and mosques, in which the name of Allah is much mentioned, would have been demolished" (22:40). Fighting was permitted to protect people's freedom to worship Allah, not to force anyone into Islām: "There is no compulsion in religion" (al-Baqarah 2:256).

For students

Many scholars, among them Ibn al-Qayyim in Zād al-Maʿād, describe the rulings on fighting as coming in stages:

- **Forbidden** in Makkah: "restrain your hands" (an-Nisāʾ 4:77).
- **Permitted** after the Hijrah (al-Ḥajj 22:39).
- **Commanded against those who fight the Muslims**: "Fight in the way of Allah those who fight you, and do not transgress" (al-Baqarah 2:190).
- **Commanded more generally** in the last years, in Sūrat at-Tawbah, against the idolaters of Arabia who had broken their treaties, and against the hostile powers around it.

The scholars discuss how these stages relate to each other, and which apply in which situation. This belongs to the study of fiqh and tafsīr with qualified teachers, and the decision to fight belongs to the legitimate authority, not to individuals.

The rules of war the Prophet ﷺ set

Before Islām, Arab warfare had few limits. The Prophet ﷺ brought rules that protected those who did not fight, and he taught them to every army he sent out. Buraydah narrated that when the Prophet ﷺ appointed a commander, he advised him to fear Allah and treat the Muslims with him well, then said:

اغْزُوا بِاسْمِ اللَّهِ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ، قَاتِلُوا مَنْ كَفَرَ بِاللَّهِ، اغْزُوا وَلَا تَغُلُّوا، وَلَا تَغْدِرُوا، وَلَا تَمْثُلُوا، وَلَا تَقْتُلُوا وَلِيدًا

“Fight in the name of Allah and in the path of Allah. Fight those who disbelieve in Allah. Fight, but do not steal from the spoils, do not betray, do not mutilate, and do not kill a child.”

Narrated by Muslim (1731). The ḥadīth goes on to command that the enemy first be invited to Islām or to peace.

Rule	Evidence
Do not kill women and children	Ibn ʿUmar: a woman was found killed in one of the battles, and the Prophet ﷺ forbade the killing of women and children (al-Bukhārī 3015, Muslim 1744).
Do not kill the elderly, monks, or destroy without need	Abū Bakr’s advice to his commander Yazīd ibn Abī Sufyān: do not kill a woman, a child or an old man, do not cut down fruit-bearing trees, do not destroy a building, and leave monks in their monasteries (Mālik, al-Muwaṭṭaʾ, Book of Jihād).
Do not mutilate, do not betray	The ḥadīth of Buraydah above (Muslim 1731).
Do not exceed limits	“Fight… those who fight you, and do not transgress; Allah does not love the transgressors” (al-Baqarah 2:190).
Keep treaties and promises	Before Badr, Ḥudhayfah and his father had promised Quraysh not to fight. The Prophet ﷺ said: “Go back. We will keep our word to them and seek Allah’s help against them” (Muslim 1787).
Do not kill envoys	To the envoys of Musaylimah the liar: “Were it not that envoys are not killed, I would have struck your necks” (Abū Dāwūd 2761).
Accept peace when it is offered	“And if they incline to peace, then incline to it [also] and rely upon Allah” (al-Anfāl 8:61).
Treat prisoners well	The righteous “give food, despite loving it, to the poor, the orphan and the captive” (al-Insān 76:8). Prisoners could be freed as a favour or for ransom (Muḥammad 47:4).
Never harm a person under treaty	“Whoever kills a muʿāhad will not smell the fragrance of Paradise” (al-Bukhārī 3166).

لَا تَتَمَنَّوْا لِقَاءَ الْعَدُوِّ، وَسَلُوا اللَّهَ الْعَافِيَةَ، فَإِذَا لَقِيتُمُوهُمْ فَاصْبِرُوا، وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ الْجَنَّةَ تَحْتَ ظِلَالِ السُّيُوفِ

“Do not wish to meet the enemy, and ask Allah for well-being. But when you meet them, be patient, and know that Paradise lies under the shade of swords.”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (2966, 3025) and Muslim (1742). He did not seek war; he asked Allah for well-being.

How many battles were there?

The scholars of sīrah, such as Ibn Isḥāq and Ibn Saʿd, counted **27 ghazawāt**, expeditions in which the Prophet ﷺ went out himself. Actual fighting took place in **nine** of them: Badr, Uḥud, al-Khandaq, Banū Qurayẓah, Banū al-Muṣṭaliq, Khaybar, the Opening of Makkah, Ḥunayn and aṭ-Ṭāʾif. In the rest, the enemy fled, a treaty was made, or no one came out to meet them. The Companion Zayd ibn Arqam, asked how many expeditions the Prophet ﷺ made, said nineteen, and that he himself took part in seventeen (al-Bukhārī 3949): he was counting those he knew of, and the difference is only in how the expeditions are counted.

Besides these, the Prophet ﷺ sent out many **sarāyā**: the sīrah books count between about 35 and more than 50. In all, these ten years were remarkably light in bloodshed for what they achieved. One well-known count, by Qāḍī Muḥammad Sulaymān Manṣūrpūrī in his book Raḥmatan lil-ʿĀlamīn, puts the total killed on both sides, across all the battles, at about a thousand people.


Where the battles took place
A simplified map. Positions are approximate.
N
MEDITERRANEAN
Mu'tah · 8 AH
SHĀM
Dūmat al-Jandal · 5 AH
SINAI
Aylah
Tabūk · 9 AH
EGYPT
march to Tabūk, about 700 km
Wādī al-Qurā · 7 AH
NAJD
Khaybar · 7 AH
Uḥud · 3 AH
Madinah
RED SEA
Badr · 2 AH
HIJĀZ
al-Abwā' · 2 AH
al-Muraysī' · 5 AH
al-Ḥudaybiyah · 6 AH
Ḥunayn · 8 AH
Makkah
aṭ-Ṭā'if · 8 AH
City
Fighting took place
Expedition or treaty, no battle

Ten years of the maghāzī, year by year



* Some date Banū al-Muṣṭaliq to 6 AH and al-Khandaq to 4 AH. The years run from Muḥarram; CE years are approximate.

The four stages of the maghāzī

Stage	Years	What happened
Defence and the first victory	1–2 AH	Patrols and treaties with nearby tribes; then Badr, which made the Muslims a power in Arabia.
Testing and endurance	3–5 AH	Uḥud, the treachery at ar-Rajīʿ and Biʾr Maʿūnah, and the great siege of the Trench, after which Quraysh never attacked Madinah again.
Truce and expansion	6–7 AH	The Treaty of al-Ḥudaybiyah, letters to the kings, the opening of Khaybar, and many people entering Islām in peace.
Victory and completion	8–9 AH	Muʾtah, the Opening of Makkah, Ḥunayn, aṭ-Ṭāʾif and Tabūk; then the Year of Delegations, when Arabia came to Islām.

01

THE BATTLES OF THE PROPHET 01 · ﷺ

يَوْمَ الْفُرْقَانِ

YAWM AL-FURQĀN · THE DAY OF CRITERION

Badr

The first expeditions and the Battle of Badr

1 – 2 AH · 622 – 624 CE · Madinah to Badr

313
Muslims, about the number of Ṭālūt's army

17
Ramaḍān 2 AH, the day of Badr

14
martyrs, against 70 Quraysh killed

Part 2 The first expeditions

In the first year after the Hijrah, the Prophet ﷺ began sending out small patrols. The first banner was given to his uncle **Ḥamzah**, who led thirty Muhājirūn to the coast at Sīf al-Baḥr, where they met a caravan of Quraysh; a local chief stood between them and there was no fighting. Others followed under ʿUbaydah ibn al-Ḥārith and Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ, who said he was the first of the Arabs to shoot an arrow in the path of Allah (al-Bukhārī, 3728).

In the second year the Prophet ﷺ went out himself: to **Waddān** (al-Abwāʾ), where he made a treaty with Banū Ḍamrah; to **Buwāṭ**; to **al-ʿUshayrah**, where he made a treaty with Banū Mudlij; and to **Safawān** (called the first Badr) in pursuit of Kurz ibn Jābir, who had raided the grazing camels of Madinah. These expeditions did several things at once: they showed Quraysh that their trade route to Shām was no longer safe, they made alliances with the tribes along the coast, and they trained the Muslims.

The sariyyah of Nakhlah

In Rajab 2 AH, the Prophet ﷺ sent ʿAbdullāh ibn Jaḥsh with a small group and a sealed letter, to be opened after two days. It told them to go to Nakhlah, between Makkah and aṭ-Ṭāʾif, and watch Quraysh. A caravan passed, and they attacked it, killing ʿAmr ibn al-Ḥaḍramī and taking two prisoners. It was the last day of Rajab, a sacred month. The Prophet ﷺ said: "I did not command you to fight in the sacred month," and Quraysh spread the news across Arabia. Then Allah revealed:

يَسْأَلُونَكَ عَنِ الشَّهْرِ الْحَرَامِ قِتَالٍ فِيهِ ۖ قُلْ قِتَالٌ فِيهِ كَبِيرٌ ۖ وَصَدٌّ عَن سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَكُفْرٌ بِهِ وَالْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرَامِ وَإِخْرَاجُ أَهْلِهِ مِنْهُ أَكْبَرُ عِندَ اللَّهِ

"They ask you about fighting in the sacred month. Say: Fighting in it is a great sin; but turning people from the way of Allah, disbelief in Him, [preventing access to] al-Masjid al-Ḥarām and driving its people out of it are greater in the sight of Allah."

Al-Baqarah 2:217.

Battle 1 The Battle of Badr: at a glance

Date	Friday, 17 Ramaḍān 2 AH (March 624 CE)
Place	The wells of Badr, about 150 km south-west of Madinah
Muslims	About 313 men, with two horses and seventy camels, taking turns to ride
Quraysh	About 950 to 1,000 men, with around a hundred horses
Leaders	The Prophet ﷺ; for Quraysh, Abū Jahl and the chiefs of Makkah
Outcome	A decisive Muslim victory. 14 Muslims martyred; 70 of Quraysh killed and 70 captured
In the Qur'an	Sūrat al-Anfāl (8), and Āl ʿImrān 3:123–127
Its name	Yawm al-Furqān, "the Day of Criterion", when truth was separated from falsehood (al-Anfāl 8:41)

The cause: the caravan of Abū Sufyān

A great caravan of Quraysh was returning from Shām under Abū Sufyān, carrying wealth in which almost every family of Makkah had a share. This was the same Quraysh that had taken the homes and property of the Muhājirūn. The Prophet ﷺ called on the Muslims to go out to it. Many did not come, because they did not expect a battle, only a caravan. About three hundred and thirteen went out. Al-Barāʾ said: "We used to say that the people of Badr were three hundred and ten-odd, the number of the companions of Ṭālūt who crossed the river with him, and only believers crossed with him" (al-Bukhārī, 3957).

Abū Sufyān learned that the Muslims had come out. He sent a messenger to Makkah crying for help, and turned his caravan away towards the coast, and escaped. Quraysh came out in force, about a thousand men. When they heard the caravan was safe, some wanted to return, but Abū Jahl refused: "By Allah, we will not go back until we reach Badr, stay there three days, slaughter camels, eat, drink wine and have singing girls play for us, so that the Arabs hear of us and fear us forever."

> وَإِذْ يَعِدُكُمُ اللَّهُ إِحْدَى الطَّائِفَتَيْنِ أَنَّهَا لَكُمْ وَتَوَدُّونَ أَنَّ غَيْرَ ذَاتِ الشَّوْكَةِ تَكُونُ لَكُمْ وَيُرِيدُ اللَّهُ أَن يُحِقَّ الْحَقَّ بِكَلِمَاتِهِ
>
> **"And [remember] when Allah promised you one of the two groups, that it would be yours, and you wished that the unarmed one would be yours. But Allah intended to establish the truth by His words."**
>
> Al-Anfāl 8:7. The two groups were the caravan and the army.

The council: “We will fight on your right and your left”

Now the Muslims faced an army instead of a caravan, and the Prophet ﷺ consulted them. Abū Bakr and ʿUmar spoke well. Then al-Miqdād ibn al-Aswad stood and said: “We will not say to you what the people of Mūsā said: Go, you and your Lord, and fight. Rather, we will fight on your right and on your left, in front of you and behind you.” Ibn Masʿūd said: “I saw the face of the Prophet ﷺ shine with joy at that” (al-Bukhārī, 3952).

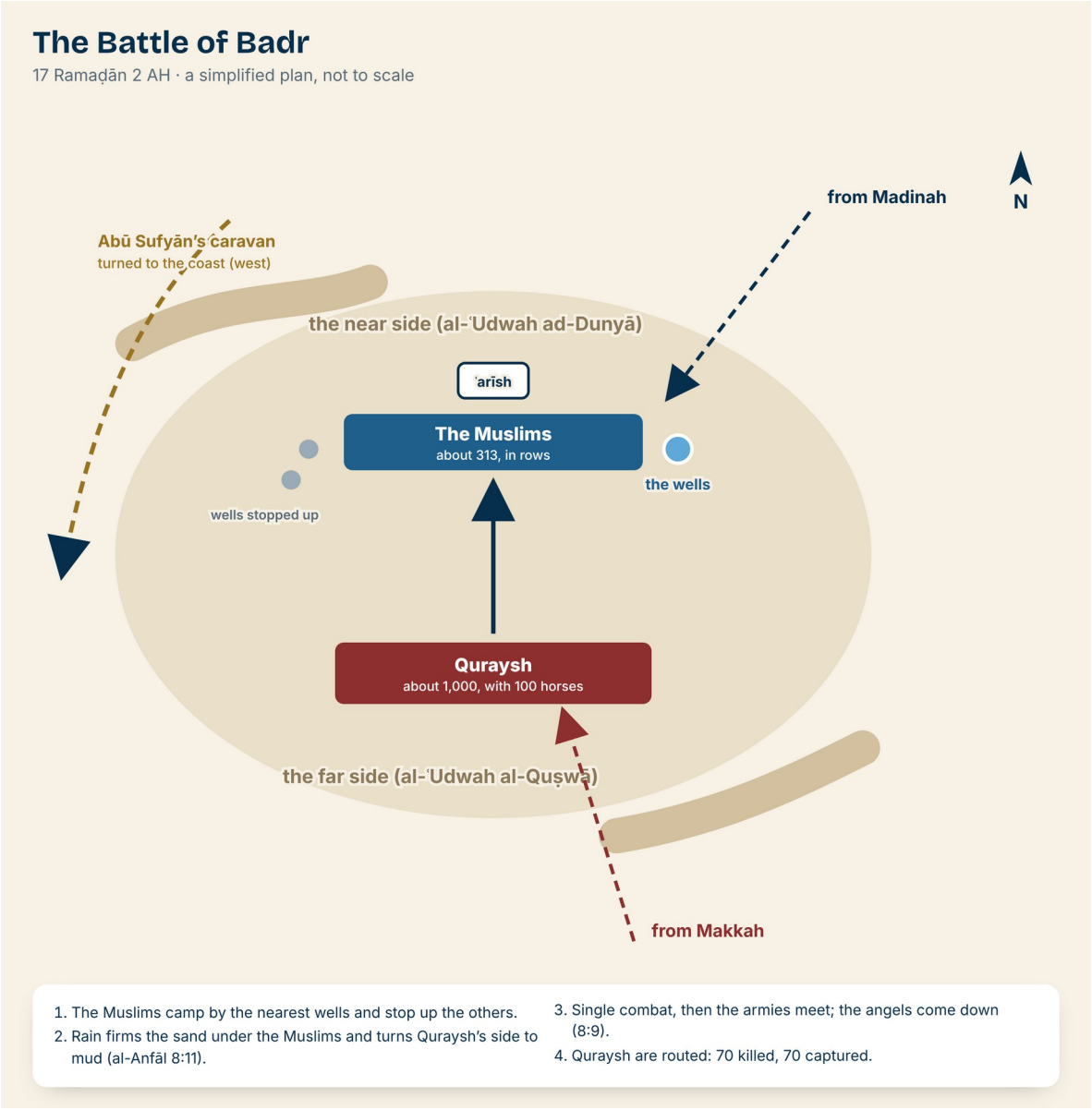
But the Prophet ﷺ kept saying: “Advise me, O people,” because he wanted to hear from the Anṣār, whose pledge at al-ʿAqabah had been to protect him inside Madinah. Their leader Saʿd understood and said: “It seems you mean us, O Messenger of Allah. By the One in whose hand is my soul, if you commanded us to plunge our horses into the sea, we would do it” (Muslim, 1779; the books of sīrah name him as Saʿd ibn Muʿādh). It is reported that the Prophet ﷺ replied: “Go forward, and receive glad tidings: Allah has promised me one of the two groups.” Anas narrated that he then pointed on the ground to the places where the leaders of Quraysh would be killed, saying “This is where so-and-so will fall,” and not one of them fell beyond the place he had pointed to (Muslim, 1779).

The night before the battle

It is reported in the sīrah that al-Ḥubāb ibn al-Mundhir asked: “Is this a place Allah has commanded you to camp in, or is it a matter of opinion and war strategy?” When the Prophet ﷺ said it was strategy, al-Ḥubāb advised camping at the well nearest to the enemy and stopping up the others, so that the Muslims would have water and Quraysh would not. The Prophet ﷺ took his advice. A shelter (ʿarīsh) of palm branches was built for him overlooking the battlefield.

That night Allah sent rain. For the Muslims it firmed the sand under their feet; for Quraysh, on lower ground, it became mud. And Allah sent a calm sleep over the believers, though they were outnumbered three to one:

> إِذْ يُغَشِّيكُمُ النُّعَاسَ أَمَنَةً مِّنْهُ وَيُنَزِّلُ عَلَيْكُم مِّنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً لِّيُطَهِّرَكُم بِهِ وَيُذْهِبَ عَنكُمْ رِجْزَ الشَّيْطَانِ وَلِيَرْبِطَ عَلَىٰ قُلُوبِكُمْ وَيُثَبِّتَ بِهِ الْأَقْدَامَ
>
> **“[Remember] when He covered you with drowsiness, giving security from Him, and sent down rain upon you from the sky to purify you, remove from you the whisperings of Shayṭān, strengthen your hearts and make your feet firm.”**
>
> Al-Anfāl 8:11.



The duʿāʾ of the Prophet ﷺ

In the morning the Prophet ﷺ arranged the rows himself. Then he went into the shelter and turned to his Lord. ʿUmar narrated that the Prophet ﷺ looked at the idolaters, who were a thousand, and his Companions, who were three hundred and nineteen, then faced the qiblah, raised his hands and called on his Lord:

اللَّهُمَّ أَنْجِزْ لِي مَا وَعَدْتَنِي، اللَّهُمَّ آتِ مَا وَعَدْتَنِي، اللَّهُمَّ إِنْ تَهْلِكْ هَذِهِ الْعِصَابَةُ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْإِسْلَامِ لَا تُعْبَدْ فِي الْأَرْضِ

“O Allah, fulfil for me what You promised me. O Allah, give me what You promised me. O Allah, if this small band of the people of Islām perishes, You will not be worshipped on the earth.”

Narrated by Muslim (1763).

He kept calling on his Lord with his hands raised until his cloak fell from his shoulders. Abū Bakr picked it up, put it back on his shoulders, held him from behind and said: “O Prophet of Allah, enough of your pleading with your Lord. He will fulfil what He promised you.” And Allah revealed: “When you were calling upon your Lord for help, and He answered you: I will reinforce you with a thousand angels, following one another” (al-Anfāl 8:9) (Muslim, 1763). Then the Prophet ﷺ came out reciting: “The assembly will be defeated, and they will turn their backs” (al-Qamar 54:45) (al-Bukhārī, 3953).

The battle

The battle began, as was the custom, with single combat. ʿUtbah ibn Rabīʿah, his brother Shaybah and his son al-Walīd came out. The Prophet ﷺ sent out three of his own family: **Ḥamzah**, **ʿAlī** and **ʿUbaydah ibn al-Ḥārith**. Ḥamzah and ʿAlī killed their opponents quickly; ʿUbaydah and his opponent wounded each other, and ʿAlī and Ḥamzah finished him and carried ʿUbaydah back. He died of his wound on the way home. ʿAlī said that the verse “These are two disputants who disputed about their Lord” (al-Ḥajj 22:19) was revealed about them (al-Bukhārī, 3965–3967).

Then the armies met. The Prophet ﷺ took a handful of pebbles and dust and threw it towards Quraysh, and Allah made it reach their eyes:

فَلَمْ تَقْتُلُوهُمْ وَلَٰكِنَّ اللَّهَ قَتَلَهُمْ ۚ وَمَا رَمَيْتَ إِذْ رَمَيْتَ وَلَٰكِنَّ اللَّهَ رَمَىٰ

“And you did not kill them, but it was Allah who killed them. And you did not throw when you threw, but it was Allah who threw.”

Al-Anfāl 8:17.

The angels fought alongside the believers, as Allah promised (al-Anfāl 8:12). Jibrīl came to the Prophet ﷺ and asked: “How do you count the people of Badr among you?” He said: “Among the best of the Muslims.” Jibrīl said: “And so are the angels who were present at Badr” (al-Bukhārī, 3992). Quraysh broke and fled.

The death of Abū Jahl

ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf was standing in the ranks between two young boys of the Anṣār. One of them whispered: “Uncle, do you know Abū Jahl? I have been told he insults the Messenger of Allah ﷺ. By the One in whose hand is my soul, if I see him, I will not leave him until one of us dies.” The other said the same. When ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān pointed him out, they rushed at him with their swords and struck him down. They were **Muʿādh ibn ʿAmr ibn al-Jamūḥ** and **Muʿādh ibn ʿAfrā’** (al-Bukhārī, 3141). Ibn Masʿūd, once a poor shepherd of Makkah, found Abū Jahl at his last breath and ended his life (al-Bukhārī, 3962). The man who had tortured the weak Muslims of Makkah died at the hands of two boys and a shepherd.

After the battle

The bodies of the leaders of Quraysh were thrown into a dry well (al-qalīb). The Prophet ﷺ stood over it and called them by name: “Would it not have been better for you if you had obeyed Allah and His Messenger? We have found what our Lord promised us to be true. Have you found what your Lord promised you to be true?” ʿUmar asked how he could speak to bodies without souls. He said: “You do not hear what I say better than they do” (al-Bukhārī, 3976).

Seventy men of Quraysh had been captured. The Prophet ﷺ consulted his Companions. Abū Bakr advised taking ransom, hoping that Allah would guide them; ʿUmar advised killing the leaders of disbelief. The Prophet ﷺ chose Abū Bakr’s view, and Allah revealed verses that agreed with ʿUmar (al-Anfāl 8:67–69), then made the ransom lawful (Muslim, 1763). It is reported that some prisoners who could read and write, and had no money, were set free for teaching ten children of Madinah to write (Aḥmad).

Fourteen Muslims were martyred at Badr, six of the Muhājirūn and eight of the Anṣār. Among them was the young **ʿUmayr ibn al-Ḥumām**, who heard the Prophet ﷺ say: “Rise to a Paradise as wide as the heavens and the earth.” He was eating some dates, and said: “If I live until I finish these dates, that is a long life,” threw them down, fought and was killed (Muslim, 1901).

The rank of the people of Badr

When Ḥāṭib ibn Abī Baltaʿah later made a serious mistake, ʿUmar wanted to punish him. The Prophet ﷺ said: “He was present at Badr. How do you know? Perhaps Allah looked at the people of Badr and said: Do what you wish, for I have forgiven you” (al-Bukhārī, 3007). The Companions who fought at Badr were honoured above others for the rest of their lives.

> وَلَقَدْ نَصَرَكُمُ اللَّهُ بِبَدْرٍ وَأَنتُمْ أَذِلَّةٌ ۖ فَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ
>
> **“And Allah had already given you victory at Badr while you were few and weak. So fear Allah, that you may be grateful.”**
>
> Āl ʿImrān 3:123.

For students

Sūrat al-Anfāl was revealed about Badr. It opens with the question of the spoils ("they ask you about the anfāl", 8:1) and teaches that victory is from Allah, that the believers must obey Allah and His Messenger and not dispute, and sets the law of dividing the spoils: a fifth for Allah and His Messenger, kin, orphans, the poor and the traveller (8:41).

Badr shows the place of **shūrā** (consultation) in the Prophet's ﷺ leadership: he consulted before the battle, on where to camp, and about the prisoners.

Lessons from Badr

1	**Victory is from Allah, not from numbers.** Three hundred, poorly armed, defeated a thousand.
2	**Take the means, then rely on Allah.** The Prophet ﷺ arranged the rows, took good advice about the wells, then spent the night in duʿāʾ.
3	**Consult, and listen.** Even a prophet asked: "Advise me, O people."
4	**Courage is not about age.** Two boys brought down the greatest enemy of Islām.
5	**Pride brings its own downfall.** Abū Jahl wanted Arabia to hear of his feast; it heard of his death.

After Badr Banū Qaynuqāʿ and as-Sawīq

When the Prophet ﷺ arrived in Madinah, he made a covenant with its Jewish tribes, Banū Qaynuqāʿ, Banū an-Naḍīr and Banū Qurayẓah, to live in peace and defend Madinah together. After Badr, Banū Qaynuqāʿ, a tribe of goldsmiths and traders who lived inside Madinah, openly showed their hostility. The Prophet ﷺ gathered them in their market and warned them; they replied: “Do not be deceived because you met a people who knew nothing of war. By Allah, if you fight us, you will know that we are the real men.” The sīrah books report that they then humiliated a Muslim woman in their market, and that the killings that followed sparked open conflict.

In Shawwāl 2 AH the Prophet ﷺ besieged their quarter for about fifteen days, until they surrendered. At the intercession of ʿAbdullāh ibn Ubayy, their old ally, they were allowed to leave Madinah with their families, and they settled in Adhriʿāt in Shām. Some scholars count this as a ghazwah of its own.

In Dhul-Ḥijjah of the same year, Abū Sufyān, who had sworn to avenge Badr, raided the edge of Madinah with a small band, burned some palm trees and killed two men. The Prophet ﷺ pursued him; Abū Sufyān’s men fled, throwing away their supplies of sawīq (barley meal) to lighten their load, so the expedition was called **as-Sawīq**.

02

THE BATTLES OF THE PROPHET 02 · ﷺ

وَلَا تَهِنُوا وَلَا تَحْزَنُوا

A LESSON IN OBEDIENCE AND PATIENCE

Uḥud

Uḥud, and the trials that followed it

3 – 4 AH · 624 – 626 CE · Uḥud, Biʾr Maʿūnah, Banū an-Naḍīr

700	50	70
Muslims against 3,000 Quraysh	archers placed on the hill	martyrs, among them Ḥamzah

Part 3 Between Badr and Uḥud

Badr shook Arabia. Quraysh lost their chiefs and their pride, and their trade routes to Shām were now in danger. Through the year 3 AH the Prophet ﷺ led expeditions to **Dhū Amarr** in Najd, where the tribes of Ghaṭafān had gathered and then scattered into the mountains, and to **Buḥrān**, against Banū Sulaym, who also dispersed. Meanwhile Quraysh spent the profits of Abū Sufyān's caravan, the one that escaped at Badr, on an army for revenge. Allah says of this: "Indeed, those who disbelieve spend their wealth to avert people from the way of Allah. They will spend it, then it will be a regret for them, then they will be overcome" (al-Anfāl 8:36).

Battle 2 The Battle of Uḥud: at a glance

Date	Saturday, Shawwāl 3 AH (March 625 CE)
Place	Below Mount Uḥud, about 5 km north of the Prophet's Mosque
Muslims	About 1,000 set out; about 300 hypocrites turned back, leaving about 700
Quraysh	About 3,000, with some 200 horses, and women urging them on
Leaders	The Prophet ﷺ; for Quraysh, Abū Sufyān, with Khālid ibn al-Walīd and ʿIkrimah ibn Abī Jahl leading the cavalry
Outcome	A Muslim victory turned into a reverse when the archers left their post. About 70 Muslims martyred; about 22 of Quraysh killed
In the Qur'an	Āl ʿImrān 3:121–179, about sixty verses

A dream, and a decision

Before the battle, the Prophet ﷺ saw in a dream that he shook a sword and its blade broke, and he saw cows being slaughtered. He later explained that the broken sword and the cows were the believers who would be killed at Uḥud (al-Bukhārī 3622, Muslim 2272).

His own view was to stay in Madinah and fight from its streets and houses, and ʿAbdullāh ibn Ubayy agreed. But many Companions, especially young men who had missed Badr, longed to meet the enemy in the open. The Prophet ﷺ went into his house and came out wearing his armour. They felt they had pressed him and said: "Stay, if you wish." He replied: "It is not fitting for a prophet who has put on his armour to take it off until Allah judges between him and his enemy." (Al-Bukhārī mentions this in the Book of Holding Fast to the Qur'an and Sunnah.)

The hypocrites turn back

About a thousand set out. On the way, ʿAbdullāh ibn Ubayy turned back with about three hundred men, saying: "He obeyed them and disobeyed me. Why should we get ourselves killed?" Two clans of the believers, Banū Salimah and Banū Ḥārithah, nearly lost heart too, but Allah made them firm

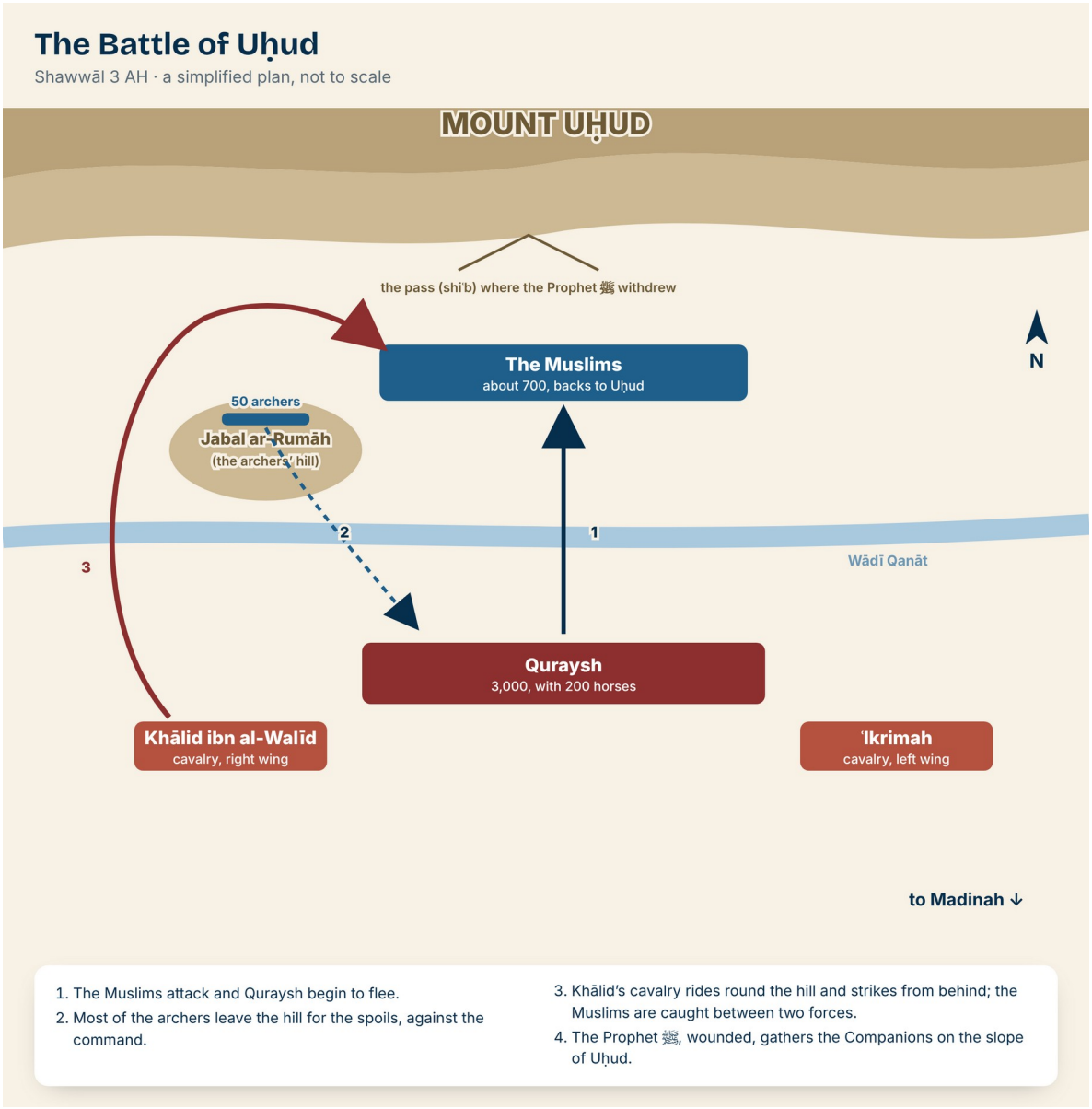
(Āl ʿImrān 3:122; al-Bukhārī 4051). Allah exposed the hypocrites: “They said with their mouths what was not in their hearts” (3:167).

The archers on the hill

The Prophet ﷺ placed Mount Uḥud behind his army and faced Quraysh, who stood between him and Madinah. On a small hill to his left, now called Jabal ar-Rumāh (the archers’ hill), he placed fifty archers under ʿ**Abdullāh ibn Jubayr**, to stop the Quraysh cavalry from riding round behind the Muslims. His command to them was absolute:

> إِنْ رَأَيْتُمُونَا تَخْطَفُنَا الطَّيْرُ فَلَا تَبْرَحُوا مَكَانَكُمْ هَذَا حَتَّى أُرْسِلَ إِلَيْكُمْ، وَإِنْ رَأَيْتُمُونَا هَزَمْنَا الْقَوْمَ وَأَوْطَأْنَاهُمْ فَلَا تَبْرَحُوا حَتَّى أُرْسِلَ إِلَيْكُمْ
>
> **“If you see birds snatching us, do not leave this place of yours until I send for you. And if you see that we have defeated them and trampled them, do not leave until I send for you.”**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3039), from al-Barāʾ ibn ʿĀzib.

The Prophet ﷺ held up a sword and asked: “Who will take this sword and give it its right?” Many reached for it, but he gave it to **Abū Dujānah**, who tied a red band round his head and fought with it until he split the heads of the idolaters (Muslim, 2470).



Victory, then disobedience

The battle went well for the Muslims at first. The standard-bearers of Quraysh fell one after another, and their army broke and fled, leaving their camp. Allah describes it: “And Allah had certainly fulfilled His promise to you when you were killing them by His permission…”. Then most of the archers, seeing the enemy in flight, cried: “The spoils! The spoils!” ʿAbdullāh ibn Jubayr reminded them of the Prophet’s ﷺ command, but they said: “By Allah, we will go to the people and take our share,” and left the hill (al-Bukhārī, 3039). Only a few stayed with him.

حَتَّىٰ إِذَا فَشِلْتُمْ وَتَنَازَعْتُمْ فِي الْأَمْرِ وَعَصَيْتُم مِّن بَعْدِ مَا أَرَاكُم مَّا تُحِبُّونَ ۚ مِنكُم مَّن يُرِيدُ الدُّنْيَا وَمِنكُم مَّن يُرِيدُ الْآخِرَةَ

"...until, when you lost courage and fell to disputing about the order and disobeyed after He had shown you what you love. Among you are some who desire this world, and among you are some who desire the Hereafter."

Āl ʿImrān 3:152.

Khālid ibn al-Walīd, then still an idolater, saw the hill empty. He led his cavalry round it, killed ʿAbdullāh ibn Jubayr and the archers who had stayed, and struck the Muslims from behind. The fleeing Quraysh turned back. The Muslims were caught between two forces, and in the confusion some even struck at each other.

"Muḥammad has been killed"

A cry went up that the Prophet ﷺ had been killed. Some Muslims fled; others sat down in despair. **Anas ibn an-Naḍr**, who had missed Badr and promised that Allah would see what he would do, said: "O Allah, I apologise to You for what these have done, and I am free of what those have done." He went forward, saying: "O Saʿd ibn Muʿādh, Paradise! By the Lord of the Kaʿbah, I can smell its fragrance from beyond Uḥud." He was found with more than eighty wounds, so disfigured that only his sister recognised him, by his fingertips (al-Bukhārī, 2805). Allah revealed about him and men like him: "Among the believers are men who have been true to what they promised Allah" (al-Aḥzāb 33:23).

وَمَا مُحَمَّدٌ إِلَّا رَسُولٌ قَدْ خَلَتْ مِن قَبْلِهِ الرُّسُلُ ۚ أَفَإِن مَّاتَ أَوْ قُتِلَ انقَلَبْتُمْ عَلَىٰ أَعْقَابِكُمْ

"Muḥammad is not but a messenger. [Other] messengers have passed on before him. So if he were to die or be killed, would you turn back on your heels?"

Āl ʿImrān 3:144, revealed about the cry at Uḥud. Abū Bakr recited it on the day the Prophet ﷺ died.

The Prophet ﷺ wounded

The Prophet ﷺ was in real danger. His face was cut, a front tooth was broken, and the rings of his helmet were driven into his cheek. Fāṭimah washed the blood from his face while ʿAlī poured water, and when the bleeding would not stop, she burned a piece of mat and pressed its ash into the wound (al-Bukhārī 2911, Muslim 1790). Wiping the blood from his face, he said: "How can a people succeed who have wounded their prophet and broken his tooth, while he calls them to Allah?" Then

Allah revealed: “Not for you is the decision at all” (3:128) (Muslim, 1791). In another report, he said even then: “O Allah, forgive my people, for they do not know” (al-Bukhārī, 3477: Ibn Masʿūd reports him describing a prophet who said this, and some scholars understood it to be about himself at Uḥud).

A small band surrounded him. **Ṭalḥah ibn ʿUbaydillāh** shielded him with his hand until it was paralysed (al-Bukhārī, 3724). **Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ** shot arrow after arrow, and the Prophet ﷺ said to him: “Shoot, may my father and mother be your ransom” (al-Bukhārī, 4055). The books of sīrah tell of **Nusaybah bint Kaʿb** (Umm ʿUmārah) fighting to protect him, and of Abū Dujānah making his back a shield. The Prophet ﷺ led them up into a pass on the slope of Uḥud, where Quraysh could not reach them.

Ḥamzah, the master of the martyrs

The Prophet’s ﷺ uncle **Ḥamzah**, the Lion of Allah, was killed by **Waḥshī**, an Abyssinian slave who had been promised his freedom if he killed him. Waḥshī waited behind a rock and threw his spear (al-Bukhārī, 4072). The sīrah books report that Hind bint ʿUtbah, whose father had been killed at Badr, mutilated his body, and that the Prophet ﷺ was overcome with grief when he saw it. Years later, both Waḥshī and Hind accepted Islām. Waḥshī said: “I killed the best of people, and I hope to kill the worst,” and it was his spear that killed Musaylimah the liar.

Abū Sufyān’s cry

When the fighting ended, Abū Sufyān called from the mountain: “Is Muḥammad among the people?” The Prophet ﷺ told the Companions not to answer. He asked about Abū Bakr and ʿUmar, then said: “These have been killed.” ʿUmar could not hold back: “You lie, enemy of Allah! Those you named are alive.” Abū Sufyān cried: “Be exalted, Hubal!” The Prophet ﷺ told them to answer: “**Allah is Higher and more Majestic.**” He cried: “We have al-ʿUzzā and you have no ʿUzzā!” They answered: “**Allah is our Protector, and you have no protector.**” He said: “A day for the day of Badr; war goes by turns” (al-Bukhārī, 3039).

Burying the martyrs

About seventy Muslims were martyred at Uḥud (al-Bukhārī, 4078). The Prophet ﷺ had them buried in their clothes, unwashed, two or three in a grave, and asked which of them knew more Qur’an, and placed that one first in the grave (al-Bukhārī, 1343). **Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr**, once the best-dressed young man of Makkah and the first teacher sent to Madinah, carried the standard until he was killed. Khabbāb said: “We found nothing to shroud him in but a cloak: when we covered his head, his feet showed, and when we covered his feet, his head showed. So the Prophet ﷺ told us to cover his head and put some grass over his feet” (al-Bukhārī, 1276).

Jābir’s father, ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿAmr, was among the martyrs. The Prophet ﷺ said the angels kept shading him with their wings until he was lifted (al-Bukhārī, 1244), and told Jābir that Allah had spoken to his father directly and asked him to wish for anything; he wished to be sent back to be killed again (at-Tirmidhī, 3010).

هَذَا جَبَلٌ يُحِبُّنَا وَنُحِبُّهُ

“This is a mountain that loves us and we love it.”

Said by the Prophet ﷺ of Uḥud (al-Bukhārī, 4083). Even after the pain of that day, he spoke of Uḥud with love.

Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad: the next morning

The day after Uḥud, the Prophet ﷺ called out those who had fought, wounded as they were, to pursue Quraysh, so that the enemy would not think the Muslims broken. They marched to Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad, about thirteen kilometres from Madinah, and camped there for three days, lighting many fires. Abū Sufyān, who had thought of returning to finish the Muslims, heard of it and hurried back to Makkah. Allah praised them:

الَّذِينَ قَالَ لَهُمُ النَّاسُ إِنَّ النَّاسَ قَدْ جَمَعُوا لَكُمْ فَاخْشَوْهُمْ فَزَادَهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَقَالُوا حَسْبُنَا اللَّهُ وَنِعْمَ الْوَكِيلُ

“Those to whom people said: Indeed, the people have gathered against you, so fear them. But it only increased them in faith, and they said: Allah is sufficient for us, and He is the best Disposer of affairs.”

Āl ʿImrān 3:173. ʿĀʾishah said that az-Zubayr and Abū Bakr were among them (al-Bukhārī, 4077). Ibrāhīm said these words when thrown into the fire (al-Bukhārī, 4563).

For students

Āl ʿImrān 3:121–179 is the Qur’an’s own commentary on Uḥud. It explains why the believers were tested: to distinguish the believers from the hypocrites (3:166–167), to take martyrs from among them (3:140), to purify the believers (3:141), and so that they would not grieve over what they missed (3:153).

It also forgives those who fled: “Allah has already forgiven them” (3:155), and commands the Prophet ﷺ to pardon them, ask forgiveness for them and **keep consulting them** (3:159), even though consultation had led to going out to Uḥud.

Lessons from Uḥud

1	**Obedience to the Messenger ﷺ is the key to victory.** One act of disobedience by a few turned victory into loss.
2	**Love of this world weakens the believer.** “Among you are some who desire this world.”
3	**A setback is not the end.** The Prophet ﷺ marched out again the very next morning.
4	**The prophets are human and are tested.** He was wounded and bled; his message did not depend on his life, but on Allah.
5	**Keep consulting, even after a decision goes wrong** (3:159).

4 AH A year of treachery: ar-Rajīʿ and Biʾr Maʿūnah

After Uḥud, some tribes thought the Muslims weak. In Ṣafar 4 AH two terrible betrayals took place within days of each other.

ar-Rajīʿ

The Prophet ﷺ sent ten men under **ʿĀṣim ibn Thābit**. At ar-Rajīʿ, about a hundred archers of Banū Liḥyān surrounded them. ʿĀṣim and most of his men fought until they were killed. **Khubayb ibn ʿAdī** and Zayd ibn ad-Dathinah were taken and sold in Makkah to families whose men had died at Badr. While Khubayb was held prisoner, he was seen eating a bunch of grapes, though there was no fruit in Makkah at the time; "it was provision Allah gave Khubayb". Brought out to be killed, he asked to pray two rakʿahs, then said: "Were it not that you would think I fear death, I would have prayed longer." He was the first to establish the sunnah of praying two rakʿahs before being killed (al-Bukhārī, 3045).

Biʾr Maʿūnah

In the same month, at the request of a chief of Najd who promised protection, the Prophet ﷺ sent about **seventy Companions**, called **al-qurrāʾ** (the reciters) because they spent their nights in prayer and their days gathering firewood to feed the poor of the Ṣuffah. At Biʾr Maʿūnah, ʿĀmir ibn aṭ-Ṭufayl gathered the clans of Riʿl, Dhakwān and ʿUṣayyah, and they killed them all but one or two. When **Ḥarām ibn Milḥān** was speared from behind, he took the blood in his hands, poured it on his face and head, and said: "**I have succeeded, by the Lord of the Kaʿbah!**" (al-Bukhārī, 4092).

The Prophet ﷺ grieved for them as for no other loss. For a whole month he made qunūt in the dawn prayer, supplicating against Riʿl, Dhakwān and ʿUṣayyah, "who disobeyed Allah and His Messenger" (al-Bukhārī, 4090). Anas said: "We used to recite a verse revealed about them, later lifted: Convey to our people that we have met our Lord, and He is pleased with us and has made us pleased" (al-Bukhārī, 4095).

4 AH Banū an-Naḍīr, Dhāt ar-Riqāʿ and Badr al-Ākhirah

The expulsion of Banū an-Naḍīr (Rabīʿ al-Awwal 4 AH)

The Prophet ﷺ went with a few Companions to Banū an-Naḍīr, who were bound by the covenant of Madinah, to ask their help with blood money. They seated him beside one of their walls, and, as the sīrah books report, plotted to drop a millstone on him from the roof. Revelation warned him, and he rose and left. He sent word that they must leave Madinah within ten days. ʿAbdullāh ibn Ubayy secretly promised to fight with them, so they refused. Allah exposed his false promise: "If they are expelled, they will not leave with them, and if they are fought, they will not help them" (al-Ḥashr 59:12).

The Muslims besieged their fortresses for some days, and some of their palm trees were cut down, which Allah permitted (59:5; al-Bukhārī 4031). They surrendered and were allowed to leave with

their families and whatever their camels could carry, except weapons. Some even tore down their own houses to take the doors and beams (59:2). Most went to Khaybar. Their land was **fay**ʾ, taken without battle, and the Prophet ﷺ gave it mostly to the Muhājirūn, who had left everything in Makkah. Ibn ʿAbbās called **Sūrat al-Ḥashr** "Sūrat Banī an-Naḍīr" (al-Bukhārī, 4883).

Dhāt ar-Riqāʿ

The Prophet ﷺ led an expedition into Najd against clans of Ghaṭafān who were gathering. The land was so rough that, as Abū Mūsā said, "our feet were torn and my toenails fell out, and we wrapped our feet in rags (riqāʿ), so it was called Dhāt ar-Riqāʿ" (al-Bukhārī, 4128). The armies faced each other but did not fight, and the Prophet ﷺ led the **prayer of fear** (ṣalāt al-khawf), half the army praying with him while the other half stood guard (an-Nisāʾ 4:102; al-Bukhārī 4129).

On the way back, the Prophet ﷺ rested under a tree and hung up his sword. A man of the enemy took it and stood over him: "Who will protect you from me?" He said calmly: "Allah." The sword fell from the man's hand. The Prophet ﷺ did not punish him (al-Bukhārī 4135–4136); the sīrah books add that he went back to his people and called them to Islām.

For students

The date of Dhāt ar-Riqāʿ is disputed. Ibn Isḥāq places it in 4 AH, but al-Bukhārī places it **after Khaybar** (7 AH), because Abū Mūsā al-Ashʿarī, who was present, only arrived in Madinah at the time of Khaybar.

Badr al-Ākhirah (Shaʿbān 4 AH)

At Uḥud, Abū Sufyān had called: "Our appointment is Badr, next year." The Prophet ﷺ kept the appointment and camped at Badr with about 1,500 men for eight days. Abū Sufyān set out, then turned back, saying it was a year of drought. The Muslims traded at the market of Badr and returned with profit, and the standing of the Muslims in Arabia was restored after Uḥud.

03

THE BATTLES OF THE PROPHET 03 · ﷺ

وَكَفَى اللَّهُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ الْقِتَالَ

AL-AḤZĀB · THE CONFEDERATES

The Trench

al-Khandaq, Banū Qurayẓah and al-Ḥudaybiyah

5 – 6 AH · 626 – 628 CE · Madinah and al-Ḥudaybiyah

10,000
confederates came against Madinah

3,000
Muslims dug and held the trench

1,400
gave the Pledge of Riḍwān

Part 4 Dūmat al-Jandal and Banū al-Muṣṭaliq

In Rabīʿ al-Awwal 5 AH the Prophet ﷺ marched about fifteen nights' journey north to **Dūmat al-Jandal**, near the borders of Shām, where tribes had gathered to attack travellers and threaten Madinah. They scattered before he arrived. It showed that the Muslims could now reach far beyond Madinah.

Banū al-Muṣṭaliq (al-Muraysīʿ)

News came that al-Ḥārith ibn Abī Ḍirār, chief of Banū al-Muṣṭaliq of Khuzāʿah, was gathering men to attack Madinah. The Prophet ﷺ went out and met them at the water of al-Muraysīʿ, near the coast; they were defeated and many taken captive. Among the captives was **Juwayriyyah**, the chief's daughter. The Prophet ﷺ freed her and married her, and the Companions said: "They are now the in-laws of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ," and freed the captives they held. ʿĀʾishah said: "I do not know a woman who was a greater blessing to her people than she" (Abū Dāwūd, 3931).

Two trials came out of this expedition. When a quarrel broke out between a man of the Muhājirūn and a man of the Anṣār, and each called his own people, the Prophet ﷺ said: "Leave it, for it is rotten" (al-Bukhārī, 4905), condemning tribal partisanship. ʿAbdullāh ibn Ubayy said: "When we return to Madinah, the more honourable will expel the more humble." Young Zayd ibn Arqam reported it; Ibn Ubayy denied it, until Allah revealed Sūrat al-Munāfiqūn: "And to Allah belongs honour, and to His Messenger and to the believers, but the hypocrites do not know" (63:8; al-Bukhārī 4900–4904).

On the way home, ʿĀʾishah was left behind while searching for a lost necklace, and was brought back by a Companion, Ṣafwān ibn al-Muʿaṭṭal. The hypocrites spread a terrible slander about her (al-ifk). For a month no revelation came, until Allah declared her innocence in Sūrat an-Nūr (24:11–26). Her story, told in her own words, is in al-Bukhārī (4141).

For students

Ibn Saʿd and others date Banū al-Muṣṭaliq to Shaʿbān **5 AH**, before the Trench; Ibn Isḥāq dates it to **6 AH**. Both views are well known.

Battle 3 The Battle of the Trench (al-Khandaq): at a glance

Date	Shawwāl 5 AH (about February 627 CE); some date it to 4 AH
Place	The open northern side of Madinah
Muslims	About 3,000
Confederates	About 10,000: Quraysh and their allies (about 4,000), Ghaṭafān (Fazārah, Murrah, Ashjaʿ), Banū Sulaym, Banū Asad and others
Leaders	The Prophet ﷺ; Abū Sufyān led Quraysh and ʿUyaynah ibn Ḥiṣn led Ghaṭafān
Length	A siege of nearly a month
Outcome	The confederates withdrew, defeated by wind and Allah's unseen hosts. About six Muslims martyred
In the Qur'an	Al-Aḥzāb 33:9–27; the sūrah is named after them: al-Aḥzāb, "the Confederates"

The confederacy

The leaders of Banū an-Naḍīr, expelled to Khaybar, travelled to Makkah and urged Quraysh to make one final attack that would finish the Muslims. Then they went to Ghaṭafān and other tribes of Najd, promising them half the dates of Khaybar. For the first time, almost all the enemies of Islām in Arabia marched together: about ten thousand men, the largest army the Arabs had ever gathered.

Digging the trench

The Prophet ﷺ consulted his Companions. The books of sīrah report that **Salmān al-Fārisī** advised digging a trench, as the Persians did. Madinah was protected on the east and west by lava fields and on the south by palm groves and houses; only the north was open. The Prophet ﷺ divided the work among the Companions, about forty cubits for every ten men, and they dug it in a matter of days, in bitter cold and hunger.

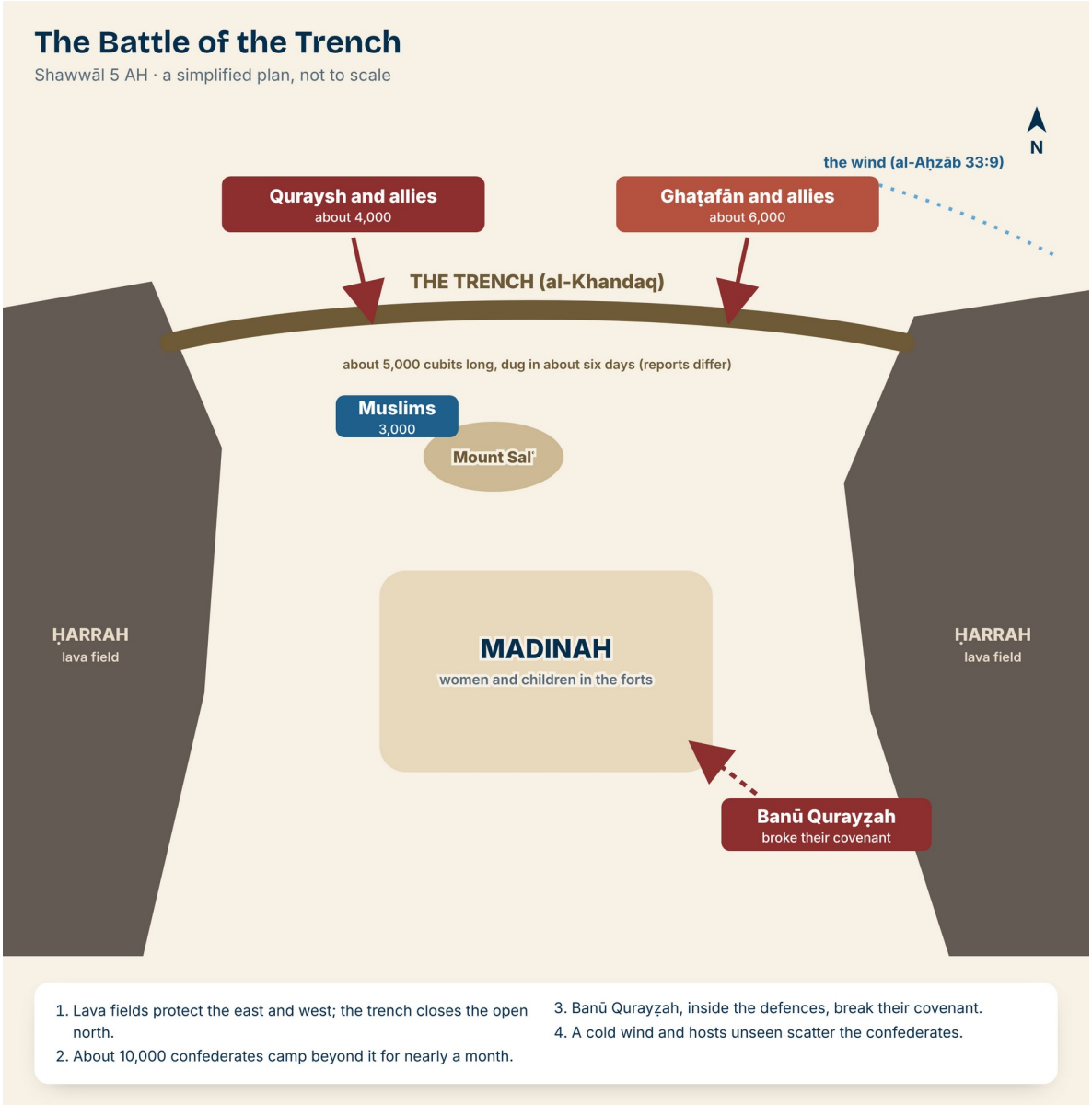
The Prophet ﷺ dug with them and carried earth until the dust covered his belly (al-Bukhārī, 4106). He was so hungry that he had tied a stone to his stomach (al-Bukhārī, 4101). As they worked, they sang:

> اللَّهُمَّ لَا عَيْشَ إِلَّا عَيْشُ الْآخِرَهْ، فَاغْفِرْ لِلْأَنْصَارِ وَالْمُهَاجِرَهْ
>
> **“O Allah, there is no life except the life of the Hereafter, so forgive the Anṣār and the Muhājirah.”**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (2834). The Companions replied: “We are those who pledged to Muḥammad to strive for as long as we live.”

When the Companions came to a rock they could not break, the Prophet ﷺ took the pickaxe and struck it, and it crumbled like sand (al-Bukhārī, 4101). In a report by Aḥmad and an-Nasāʾī, with each of three strikes he said “Allāhu akbar” and gave glad tidings: the keys of Shām, of Persia and of Yemen had been given to him. The hypocrites mocked: a man who cannot go out to relieve himself in safety promises them the treasures of Kisrā and Caesar. Allah recorded their words: “Allah and His Messenger did not promise us except delusion” (al-Aḥzāb 33:12). Within twenty years, all three lands had entered Islām.

The feast of Jābir

Jābir ibn ʿAbdillāh saw the Prophet’s ﷺ hunger and went home. His wife had a small goat and about a ṣāʿ of barley. Jābir invited the Prophet ﷺ quietly, with one or two others, but the Prophet ﷺ called out to all the people of the trench. He blessed the dough and the pot, and the whole army, about a thousand men, ate until they were full, and the pot was still bubbling and the dough still being baked (al-Bukhārī, 4101–4102).



The siege

The confederates arrived and were astonished: they had never seen a trench used in war. They camped beyond it, Quraysh near the confluence of the valleys and Ghaṭafān near Uḥud, and tried to cross it again and again. The sīrah books report that a famous warrior, **῾Amr ibn ῾Abd Wudd**, forced his horse across at a narrow point and challenged the Muslims to single combat, and that **῾Alī** met him and killed him. Arrows were exchanged day and night. One struck **Sa῾d ibn Mu῾ādh** in the vein of his arm (al-Bukhārī, 4122).

The pressure was so great that on one day the Muslims could not pray ῾Aṣr until after sunset. ῾Umar came cursing the disbelievers and said he had barely prayed; the Prophet ﷺ said he had not prayed either (al-Bukhārī, 596), and said: “They kept us from the middle prayer, the ῾Aṣr prayer. May Allah fill their houses and their graves with fire” (al-Bukhārī 2931, Muslim 627).

إِذْ جَاءُوكُم مِّن فَوْقِكُمْ وَمِنْ أَسْفَلَ مِنكُمْ وَإِذْ زَاغَتِ الْأَبْصَارُ وَبَلَغَتِ الْقُلُوبُ الْحَنَاجِرَ وَتَظُنُّونَ بِاللَّهِ الظُّنُونَا

“When they came at you from above you and from below you, and when eyes shifted and hearts reached the throats, and you assumed about Allah [various] assumptions.”

Al-Aḥzāb 33:10.

Betrayal from within

Then the worst news came. Ḥuyayy ibn Akhṭab, the chief of Banū an-Naḍīr, persuaded Kaʿb ibn Asad, chief of **Banū Qurayẓah**, to break their covenant with the Prophet ﷺ. Banū Qurayẓah lived inside the defences, in the south-east of Madinah, where the Muslim women and children were sheltering in forts. The Prophet ﷺ sent the two Saʿds, Saʿd ibn Muʿādh and Saʿd ibn ʿUbādah, to confirm it, and they found Qurayẓah openly hostile. The Muslims were now surrounded from outside and threatened from within.

The hypocrites began to slip away: “Our houses are exposed,” they said, though they were not (33:13). But the believers responded differently:

وَلَمَّا رَأَى الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الْأَحْزَابَ قَالُوا هَٰذَا مَا وَعَدَنَا اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ وَصَدَقَ اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ ۚ وَمَا زَادَهُمْ إِلَّا إِيمَانًا وَتَسْلِيمًا

“And when the believers saw the confederates, they said: This is what Allah and His Messenger promised us, and Allah and His Messenger spoke the truth. And it only increased them in faith and submission.”

Al-Aḥzāb 33:22.

Nuʿaym ibn Masʿūd

The books of sīrah tell that **Nuʿaym ibn Masʿūd** of Ghaṭafān came secretly to the Prophet ﷺ and said that he had become Muslim, though his people did not know it. The Prophet ﷺ told him: “You are only one man among us, so turn people away from us if you can, for war is deception” (the last words are in al-Bukhārī, 3030). Nuʿaym went to Banū Qurayẓah, then to Quraysh, then to Ghaṭafān, and skilfully planted distrust between them, until each side suspected the other and their alliance fell apart.

The wind

The Prophet ﷺ supplicated against the confederates:

> اللَّهُمَّ مُنْزِلَ الْكِتَابِ، سَرِيعَ الْحِسَابِ، اهْزِمِ الْأَحْزَابَ، اللَّهُمَّ اهْزِمْهُمْ وَزَلْزِلْهُمْ
>
> **"O Allah, Revealer of the Book, Swift in reckoning, defeat the confederates. O Allah, defeat them and shake them."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (2933) and Muslim (1742).

Then, on a bitterly cold night, Allah sent a fierce wind that tore down the enemy's tents, overturned their pots and put out their fires, together with angels they could not see (al-Aḥzāb 33:9). The Prophet ﷺ asked who would go and bring news of the enemy, promising that he would be with him on the Day of Judgement. No one answered in the cold and fear, until he called **Ḥudhayfah ibn al-Yamān** by name. Ḥudhayfah crossed into the enemy camp and saw Abū Sufyān warming his back at a fire; he had an arrow on his bow, but remembered the command not to provoke them. He came back and found that, as long as he was on his mission, he had not felt the cold (Muslim, 1788). By morning, the confederates were gone.

> وَرَدَّ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا بِغَيْظِهِمْ لَمْ يَنَالُوا خَيْرًا ۚ وَكَفَى اللَّهُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ الْقِتَالَ ۚ وَكَانَ اللَّهُ قَوِيًّا عَزِيزًا
>
> **"And Allah repelled those who disbelieved, in their rage, not having obtained any good. And Allah sufficed the believers against fighting. And Allah is ever Powerful and Exalted in Might."**
>
> Al-Aḥzāb 33:25.

The Prophet ﷺ said: "**Now we will go out against them, and they will not come against us**" (al-Bukhārī, 4110). And so it was: Quraysh never again marched on Madinah.

Lessons from the Trench

1	**Use every good means.** A new idea from Salmān, the hard work of digging, and planning were part of tawakkul, not opposed to it.
2	**Leaders share the hardship.** The Prophet ﷺ dug, carried earth and went hungry with his Companions.
3	**Hardship reveals hearts.** The same siege made the hypocrites say "delusion" and the believers say "this is what Allah promised us".

4	**Hope in the darkest hour.** Surrounded and starving, the Prophet ﷺ promised Shām, Persia and Yemen.
5	**Help comes from where you do not expect it**: one man, a wind, and hosts unseen.

Battle 4 Banū Qurayẓah

On the day the confederates left, the Prophet ﷺ returned home and put down his weapons. Jibrīl came and said: “Have you put down your weapons? By Allah, the angels have not put theirs down. Go out to them,” and pointed towards Banū Qurayẓah (al-Bukhārī, 4117). The Prophet ﷺ told the Companions:

> لَا يُصَلِّيَنَّ أَحَدٌ الْعَصْرَ إِلَّا فِي بَنِي قُرَيْظَةَ
>
> **“Let no one pray ʿAṣr except at Banū Qurayẓah.”**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (946); in Muslim’s narration (1770), Ẓuhr.

On the way, the time of ʿAṣr came. Some said: “We will not pray until we get there.” Others said: “That is not what he meant,” and prayed on the way. When this was mentioned to the Prophet ﷺ, he did not blame either group (al-Bukhārī, 946). The scholars take this as a great lesson: when sincere people understand a text in two reasonable ways, neither should condemn the other.

The Muslims besieged Banū Qurayẓah for about twenty-five nights. Finally they surrendered and agreed to accept the judgement of **Saʿd ibn Muʿādh**, chief of the Aws, who had been their ally for generations; they hoped he would be lenient. Saʿd, dying of the wound he received at the Trench, was carried to them. He judged that their fighting men should be killed and their women and children taken captive. The Prophet ﷺ said: “You have judged with the judgement of Allah” (al-Bukhārī 3043, 4121).

Why such a severe judgement?

This event is often misunderstood, so it should be read carefully:

- Banū Qurayẓah had a covenant with the Prophet ﷺ to defend Madinah. They broke it **in the middle of the siege**, when ten thousand men were trying to wipe out the Muslims, and their betrayal put the women and children of Madinah in direct danger. In any age, treason in war is the gravest of crimes.
- They were not judged by an enemy but by their own **ally, whose judgement they chose** themselves. Scholars have noted that Saʿd's ruling matches what their own scripture lays down for a besieged city that refuses peace (Deuteronomy 20:12–14).
- The judgement fell on the **fighting men** who had taken part in the treachery. Women and children were not killed, and the sīrah books mention men of Qurayẓah who had kept faith or accepted Islām and were spared.
- Banū Qaynuqāʿ and Banū an-Naḍīr, whose offences were lesser, had simply been sent away. The Prophet ﷺ did not treat all Jews alike; each tribe was dealt with according to its own actions. Many Jews lived under Muslim rule in peace for centuries after.

The reports in the sīrah give different numbers for those killed, from about four hundred to about nine hundred.

Saʿd's wound reopened and he died soon after. The Prophet ﷺ said: "The Throne of the Most Merciful shook at the death of Saʿd ibn Muʿādh" (al-Bukhārī 3803, Muslim 2466). The Qur'an speaks of this event in al-Aḥzāb 33:26–27.

6 AH Banū Liḥyān and Dhū Qarad

In 6 AH the Prophet ﷺ went out against **Banū Liḥyān**, the tribe that had betrayed the Companions at ar-Rajīʿ. They fled to the mountains. Then raiders of Ghaṭafān seized the Prophet's ﷺ grazing camels near Madinah. **Salamah ibn al-Akwaʿ**, a young man and a famous runner, chased them alone on foot, shooting arrows and calling: "I am Ibn al-Akwaʿ! Today is the day the mean ones perish!" He recovered the camels and much more before the cavalry arrived (al-Bukhārī 3041, Muslim 1807). The Prophet ﷺ said: "The best of our horsemen today is Abū Qatādah, and the best of our foot soldiers is Salamah" (Muslim, 1807). This expedition is called **Dhū Qarad** or al-Ghābah; al-Bukhārī and Muslim place it just before Khaybar.

6 AH The Treaty of al-Ḥudaybiyah

Date	Dhul-Qaʿdah 6 AH (March 628 CE)
Place	Al-Ḥudaybiyah, at the edge of the sacred territory, about 20 km from Makkah
Muslims	About 1,400, in iḥrām for ʿumrah, with sacrificial animals and only travellers' swords
Outcome	A ten-year truce with Quraysh. No fighting. Allah called it "a clear victory"
In the Qur'an	Sūrat al-Fatḥ (48), revealed on the way home

A journey for ʿumrah

The Prophet ﷺ saw in a dream that he and his Companions entered al-Masjid al-Ḥarām in safety, with heads shaved or hair shortened (al-Fatḥ 48:27). He set out with about 1,400 Companions in iḥrām, driving sacrificial camels, to show that they had come to worship, not to fight. Quraysh sent Khālid ibn al-Walīd with cavalry to block the road; the Prophet ﷺ took another, rougher route. Near al-Ḥudaybiyah, his camel al-Qaṣwāʾ knelt and would not move. People said she was stubborn. He said: "She is not stubborn, but she was held back by the One who held back the elephant." Then he said: "By the One in whose hand is my soul, they will not ask me for any plan that honours what Allah has made sacred, except that I will grant it to them" (al-Bukhārī, 2731).

They camped at a well with little water. The Prophet ﷺ placed an arrow from his quiver in it, and water flowed until they all drank (al-Bukhārī, 2731). Envoys came and went. ʿUrwah ibn Masʿūd of Thaqīf returned to Quraysh amazed: "I have been to Caesar, Kisrā and the Najāshī, and I have never seen a king whose companions honour him as the companions of Muḥammad honour Muḥammad" (al-Bukhārī, 2731).

The Pledge of Riḍwān

The Prophet ﷺ sent **ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān** to Quraysh. When he was held up, a rumour spread that he had been killed. The Prophet ﷺ called the Companions to a pledge under a tree, and they pledged not to flee (Muslim, 1856). Placing his right hand on his left, he said: "This is for ʿUthmān" (al-Bukhārī, 3698). Allah announced His pleasure with every one of them:

لَّقَدْ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ إِذْ يُبَايِعُونَكَ تَحْتَ الشَّجَرَةِ فَعَلِمَ مَا فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ فَأَنزَلَ السَّكِينَةَ عَلَيْهِمْ وَأَثَابَهُمْ فَتْحًا قَرِيبًا

"Certainly was Allah pleased with the believers when they pledged allegiance to you under the tree, and He knew what was in their hearts, so He sent down tranquillity upon them and rewarded them with an imminent victory."

Al-Fatḥ 48:18. The Prophet ﷺ said: "No one who pledged under the tree will enter the Fire" (Muslim 2496; at-Tirmidhī 3860).

The terms

Quraysh sent **Suhayl ibn ʿAmr** to make peace. When the Prophet ﷺ dictated "In the name of Allah, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate," Suhayl objected: "Write: In Your name, O Allah." When he dictated "This is what Muḥammad, the Messenger of Allah, has agreed," Suhayl said: "If we believed you were the Messenger of Allah, we would not have fought you. Write: Muḥammad ibn ʿAbdillāh." ʿAlī could not bring himself to erase the words, so the Prophet ﷺ erased them with his own hand (al-Bukhārī 2699, 2731). The terms were:

1. A truce between the two sides for **ten years** (Abū Dāwūd, 2766).
2. The Muslims would **return this year** without ʿumrah, and come back next year for three days, with only sheathed swords.
3. Anyone who came to the Muslims from Quraysh without his guardian's permission would be **returned**; anyone who went from the Muslims to Quraysh would not be returned.
4. Any tribe could **ally itself with either side**. Khuzāʿah joined the Muslims and Banū Bakr joined Quraysh.

As the treaty was being written, Suhayl's own son **Abū Jandal**, a Muslim who had been imprisoned, staggered into the camp in chains. Suhayl demanded him back under the treaty, and the Prophet ﷺ, keeping his word, returned him, telling him to be patient, for Allah would make a way out for him (al-Bukhārī 2731; Aḥmad).

"Are we not on the truth?"

The Companions were heartbroken. ʿUmar went to the Prophet ﷺ: "Are you not truly the Prophet of Allah? Are we not on the truth and they on falsehood? Then why should we accept humiliation in our religion?" He replied: "I am the Messenger of Allah; I do not disobey Him, and He is my Helper." ʿUmar went to Abū Bakr and asked the same questions, and Abū Bakr gave the same answers, word for word, without having heard them (al-Bukhārī, 2731). When the Prophet ﷺ told the Companions to sacrifice and shave, at first no one moved. He went to **Umm Salamah**, who advised: "Go out, say

nothing to anyone, sacrifice your camel and call your barber." He did, and the Companions rushed to follow (al-Bukhārī, 2731).

"A clear victory"

On the way home, Allah revealed Sūrat al-Fatḥ: "Indeed, We have given you a clear victory" (48:1). ʿUmar asked: "O Messenger of Allah, is it a victory?" He said: "Yes" (al-Bukhārī 3182, Muslim 1785). The truce soon proved it:

- **Peace opened hearts.** People mixed freely with the Muslims and heard the Qur'an. Az-Zuhrī said more people entered Islām in the two years after al-Ḥudaybiyah than in all the years before it: 1,400 went to al-Ḥudaybiyah; two years later, 10,000 marched to Makkah.
- **Abū Baṣīr** and other Muslims who escaped from Makkah, and could not be received in Madinah, formed a band on the coast and attacked Quraysh's caravans, until Quraysh themselves begged the Prophet ﷺ to cancel the clause about returning them (al-Bukhārī, 2731).
- **Khālid ibn al-Walīd and ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ**, two of Quraysh's greatest commanders, came to Madinah as Muslims.
- **The Prophet ﷺ wrote to the kings**: to Heraclius of Rome, who questioned Abū Sufyān about him (al-Bukhārī, 7); to Kisrā of Persia, who tore up the letter, and the Prophet ﷺ prayed that his kingdom be torn apart (al-Bukhārī, 64); to the Najāshī of Abyssinia, al-Muqawqis of Egypt and the rulers of Bahrain, Oman and Yamāmah.

Lessons from al-Ḥudaybiyah

1	**Peace can be a victory.** What looked like a defeat opened the way to the greatest triumph.
2	**Keep your word,** even when it hurts. Abū Jandal was returned in chains because a promise had been given.
3	**Trust the Prophet ﷺ when you do not understand.** ʿUmar later said he did many good deeds to make up for that day.
4	**Listen to wise counsel,** including from women: Umm Salamah's advice saved the situation.

04

THE BATTLES OF THE PROPHET 04 · ﷺ

إِنَّا فَتَحْنَا لَكَ فَتْحًا مُّبِينًا

AL-FATḤ · THE CLEAR VICTORY

The Opening

Khaybar, Mu'tah and the Opening of Makkah

7 – 8 AH · 628 – 630 CE · Khaybar, Mu'tah, Makkah

10,000
Companions marched on Makkah

360
idols removed from around the Ka'bah

3
commanders martyred at Mu'tah

Battle 5 The Opening of Khaybar: at a glance

Date	Muḥarram 7 AH (May–June 628 CE)
Place	Khaybar, an oasis of forts and palm groves about 150 km north of Madinah
Muslims	About 1,400 (the people of al-Ḥudaybiyah), with some 200 horsemen
Opponents	The Jews of Khaybar, in a chain of fortresses, with Ghaṭafān as their allies
Outcome	The forts opened one after another. About 16 to 20 Muslims martyred
In the Qur'an	Al-Fatḥ 48:15–21, the spoils promised to the people of the tree

Why Khaybar?

Khaybar had become the centre of hostility against Madinah. The leaders of Banū an-Naḍīr who settled there had gathered the confederates for the Trench, and they were still stirring up Ghaṭafān. With Quraysh bound by the truce, the Prophet ﷺ turned to Khaybar. Only those who had been at al-Ḥudaybiyah went with him, as Allah had foretold: "Those who stayed behind will say, when you set out to take the spoils: Let us follow you" (al-Fatḥ 48:15).

He reached Khaybar at night, and, as was his practice, did not attack until morning (al-Bukhārī, 2943). When the farmers came out with their spades and baskets and saw the army, they cried: "Muḥammad and the army!" The Prophet ﷺ said: "**Allāhu akbar! Khaybar is destroyed. When we descend upon the land of a people, evil is the morning of those who were warned**" (al-Bukhārī 371, 2945).

The flag given to ʿAlī

The forts of Khaybar were strong, and some held out for days. One evening the Prophet ﷺ said:

> لَأُعْطِيَنَّ الرَّايَةَ غَدًا رَجُلًا يَفْتَحُ اللَّهُ عَلَى يَدَيْهِ، يُحِبُّ اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ، وَيُحِبُّهُ اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ
>
> **"Tomorrow I will give the flag to a man at whose hands Allah will give victory; he loves Allah and His Messenger, and Allah and His Messenger love him."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (4210) and Muslim (2406).

The Companions spent the night wondering who it would be; each hoped it would be him. In the morning the Prophet ﷺ asked for **ʿAlī**, who was suffering from sore eyes. He applied his saliva to them and they were healed as if they had never been sore, then gave him the flag. ʿAlī asked: "Shall I fight them until they are like us?" He said: "Go calmly until you reach them, then invite them to Islām and tell them their duties to Allah. **By Allah, that Allah guides a single man through you is**

better for you than the finest red camels" (al-Bukhārī 4210, Muslim 2406). The champion of Khaybar, **Marḥab**, came out boasting, and ʿAlī killed him (Muslim, 1807).

After the victory

The Prophet ﷺ agreed to let the people of Khaybar stay and work the land for half of its produce (al-Bukhārī, 2285); they remained there until the caliphate of ʿUmar. Fadak, a nearby oasis, made peace without fighting and gave half its land. Among the captives was **Ṣafiyyah bint Ḥuyayy**, daughter of the chief of Banū an-Naḍīr. The Prophet ﷺ freed her and married her, making her freedom her dowry (al-Bukhārī 371, 4200).

A Jewish woman of Khaybar presented him with a poisoned roast sheep. He took a bite and spat it out; a Companion, Bishr ibn al-Barāʾ, ate from it and later died. The woman admitted it. The Companions asked: "Shall we kill her?" He said: "No" (al-Bukhārī, 2617), though the sīrah books add that she was later put to death for Bishr. In his final illness, the Prophet ﷺ said: "O ʿĀʾishah, I still feel the pain of the food I ate at Khaybar" (al-Bukhārī, 4428). For this reason many scholars said he died a martyr.

At Khaybar, the donkey meat of domestic donkeys was forbidden (al-Bukhārī, 4199). And Jaʿfar ibn Abī Ṭālib arrived with the last emigrants from Abyssinia, after more than ten years away (al-Bukhārī, 4230). It is reported that the Prophet ﷺ embraced him and said: "I do not know which makes me happier: the opening of Khaybar or the coming of Jaʿfar."

Wādī al-Qurā and the stolen cloak

On the way back, the Prophet ﷺ besieged and opened **Wādī al-Qurā**, and Taymāʾ made peace. There, a slave named Midʿam was killed by a stray arrow, and the people said: "Congratulations to him on Paradise." The Prophet ﷺ said: "No, by the One in whose hand is my soul, the cloak he took from the spoils of Khaybar before they were divided is blazing on him with fire." A man brought back a shoelace or two he had taken, and the Prophet ﷺ said: "A shoelace of fire, or two shoelaces of fire" (al-Bukhārī, 4234). Even in victory, the smallest dishonesty was not overlooked.

7 AH ʿUmrat al-Qaḍāʾ: the ʿumrah of fulfilment

In Dhul-Qaʿdah 7 AH, a year after al-Ḥudaybiyah, the Prophet ﷺ came to Makkah with about two thousand Companions to perform the ʿumrah that had been agreed. Quraysh left the city and watched from the mountains. They had said the Muslims had been weakened by the fever of Yathrib, so the Prophet ﷺ told them to walk briskly (ramal) in the first three circuits of ṭawāf, to show their strength (al-Bukhārī, 1602). ʿAbdullāh ibn Rawāḥah walked in front of him reciting verses. They stayed the agreed three days. As they left, Ḥamzah's young daughter ran after them, calling "Uncle!" ʿAlī, Jaʿfar and Zayd each wanted to care for her. The Prophet ﷺ gave her to Jaʿfar, whose wife was her maternal aunt, saying: "The maternal aunt is like the mother," and comforted each of the three with a kind word (al-Bukhārī, 4251).

8 AH The Battle of Muʾtah

Date	Jumādā al-Ūlā 8 AH (September 629 CE)
Place	Muʾtah, east of the Dead Sea, in what is now Jordan
Muslims	About 3,000. A sariyyah: the Prophet ﷺ did not go himself
Opponents	The Byzantine army and its Arab allies; the sīrah books speak of tens of thousands, some of far more
Commanders	Zayd ibn Ḥārithah, then Jaʿfar ibn Abī Ṭālib, then ʿAbdullāh ibn Rawāḥah, then Khālid ibn al-Walīd
Outcome	The army was saved by Khālid's skilful withdrawal. About 12 Muslims martyred

The Prophet ﷺ had sent a letter to the ruler of Buṣrā with **al-Ḥārith ibn ʿUmayr**. On the way, an Arab governor allied to Rome, Shuraḥbīl ibn ʿAmr, killed him: no envoy of the Prophet ﷺ had ever been killed before. The Prophet ﷺ prepared three thousand men and, for the first time, named three commanders in turn: "Your commander is Zayd. If Zayd is killed, then Jaʿfar. If Jaʿfar is killed, then ʿAbdullāh ibn Rawāḥah" (al-Bukhārī, 4261).

At Maʿān they learned that a vast army awaited them. Some suggested writing to the Prophet ﷺ for reinforcements. The sīrah books report that ʿAbdullāh ibn Rawāḥah said: "By Allah, what you dislike is the very thing you came out for: martyrdom. We do not fight people by numbers or strength, but by this religion with which Allah has honoured us." They went on.

Zayd carried the standard until he was killed. Jaʿfar took it and fought until he was killed. Ibn ʿUmar said: "We found in his body more than ninety wounds of swords and spears, all of them in front" (al-Bukhārī, 4261). Then ʿAbdullāh ibn Rawāḥah took it and was killed. The Muslims chose **Khālid ibn al-Walīd**, a Muslim of only a few months. Khālid said: "Nine swords broke in my hand on the day of Muʾtah, and only a broad Yemeni blade remained in my hand" (al-Bukhārī, 4265). The sīrah books say that overnight he rearranged his army, moving the right wing to the left and bringing up the rear, so that the Romans thought reinforcements had come, and then withdrew in good order.

In Madinah, the Prophet ﷺ told the people what was happening as it happened: "Zayd took the flag and was struck down, then Jaʿfar took it and was struck down, then Ibn Rawāḥah took it and was struck down," and his eyes were flowing with tears, "until one of the swords of Allah took the flag, and Allah gave them victory" (al-Bukhārī, 4262). From that day Khālid was called **Sayfullāh**, the Sword of Allah. Of Jaʿfar, who it is reported lost both arms holding the standard, the Prophet ﷺ said that Allah had given him two wings to fly with in Paradise; Ibn ʿUmar would greet Jaʿfar's son with: "Peace be upon you, O son of the one with two wings" (al-Bukhārī, 3709). The Prophet ﷺ went to Jaʿfar's family and said: "Prepare food for the family of Jaʿfar, for what has befallen them has kept them busy" (Abū Dāwūd 3132, at-Tirmidhī 998).

Two sarāyā of 8 AH

- **Dhāt as-Salāsil:** the Prophet ﷺ sent ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ, newly Muslim, at the head of an army that included Abū Bakr and ʿUmar. On his return, ʿAmr asked: “Who is the most beloved of people to you?” He said: “ʿĀʾishah.” “And of men?” “Her father” (al-Bukhārī, 4358).
- **Sīf al-Baḥr (al-Khabaṭ):** Abū ʿUbaydah led three hundred men to the coast. Their food ran out until they ate leaves (khabaṭ) and each man had one date a day. Then the sea threw up a huge creature like a hill, called al-ʿanbar, and they ate from it for half a month (al-Bukhārī, 4361).

Battle 6 The Opening of Makkah: at a glance

Date	Ramaḍān 8 AH (January 630 CE). The army left Madinah on 10 Ramaḍān
Muslims	About 10,000
Cause	Quraysh helped their allies Banū Bakr attack Khuzāʿah, allies of the Muslims, breaking the Treaty of al-Ḥudaybiyah
Outcome	Makkah opened almost without fighting. A general pardon; the idols destroyed; the Kaʿbah purified
In the Qur'an	Sūrat an-Naṣr (110); al-Mumtaḥanah 60:1; al-Ḥadīd 57:10; al-Isrāʾ 17:81

The treaty broken

Under the terms of al-Ḥudaybiyah, Khuzāʿah had allied with the Muslims and Banū Bakr with Quraysh. In Shaʿbān 8 AH, Banū Bakr attacked Khuzāʿah by night at the water of al-Watīr, and men of Quraysh secretly helped them with weapons and fought alongside them, even pursuing Khuzāʿah into the sacred precinct. The sīrah books tell that ʿAmr ibn Sālim of Khuzāʿah rode to Madinah and recited a poem before the Prophet ﷺ pleading for help, and he said: "You will be helped, ʿAmr ibn Sālim."

Quraysh realised what they had done and sent **Abū Sufyān** to Madinah to renew the treaty. He went to his own daughter, Umm Ḥabībah, a wife of the Prophet ﷺ; she folded away the Prophet's ﷺ bedding so that he would not sit on it, saying: "It is the bed of the Messenger of Allah, and you are an idolater." No one would speak for him, and he returned empty-handed.

The secret preparation

The Prophet ﷺ prepared in secret, praying that the news would not reach Quraysh until the army was upon them. **Ḥāṭib ibn Abī Baltaʿah**, a Companion of Badr whose family was in Makkah, wrote a letter warning Quraysh and gave it to a woman. The Prophet ﷺ sent ʿAlī, az-Zubayr and al-Miqdād, who caught her at Rawḍat Khākh and found the letter in her hair. Ḥāṭib explained that he had done it only to protect his family, not out of disbelief. ʿUmar wanted to strike his neck; the Prophet ﷺ said: "He was at Badr…" and forgave him (al-Bukhārī, 3007). Allah revealed: "O you who have believed, do not take My enemy and your enemy as allies" (al-Mumtaḥanah 60:1).

The army left on 10 Ramaḍān. The Prophet ﷺ fasted until al-Kadīd, then broke his fast and the people broke theirs (al-Bukhārī, 4275–4276). On the way his uncle **al-ʿAbbās** met him, emigrating with his family. At Marr aẓ-Ẓahrān, close to Makkah, the Prophet ﷺ ordered every man to light a fire, and ten thousand fires lit up the night.

Abū Sufyān accepts Islām

Abū Sufyān came out with Ḥakīm ibn Ḥizām and Budayl ibn Warqāʾ to see what the fires were. The guards caught them and brought them to the Prophet ﷺ, and **Abū Sufyān accepted Islām** (al-Bukhārī, 4280). In the morning, al-ʿAbbās stood with him at a narrow point of the valley as the tribes passed by, battalion after battalion. When the Anṣār passed, their leader Saʿd ibn ʿUbādah called out: "Today is the day of slaughter!" The Prophet ﷺ said: "Saʿd has spoken wrongly. **Today is the day Allah honours the Kaʿbah**," and the flag was taken from Saʿd (al-Bukhārī, 4280). Then the Prophet ﷺ announced:

> مَنْ دَخَلَ دَارَ أَبِي سُفْيَانَ فَهُوَ آمِنٌ، وَمَنْ أَلْقَى السِّلَاحَ فَهُوَ آمِنٌ، وَمَنْ أَغْلَقَ بَابَهُ فَهُوَ آمِنٌ

"Whoever enters the house of Abū Sufyān is safe, whoever lays down his weapons is safe, and whoever closes his door is safe."

Narrated by Muslim (1780).

Entering Makkah

The army entered from four sides. The Prophet ﷺ entered from the upper side, on his camel, with **Usāmah ibn Zayd**, the son of his freed slave, riding behind him (al-Bukhārī, 4289), reciting Sūrat al-Fatḥ in a beautiful, measured voice (al-Bukhārī, 4281). The sīrah books say he bowed his head in humility until his beard almost touched his saddle. Eight years earlier he had left this city by night, hunted, with a price on his head. Only in Khālid's sector, where a band led by ʿIkrimah ibn Abī Jahl and Ṣafwān ibn Umayyah resisted, was there brief fighting; two Muslims and about a dozen of the attackers were killed (al-Bukhārī, 4280).

The idols fall

The Prophet ﷺ went to the Kaʿbah. Around it stood three hundred and sixty idols. He struck them with a stick in his hand, saying:

> جَاءَ الْحَقُّ وَزَهَقَ الْبَاطِلُ ۚ إِنَّ الْبَاطِلَ كَانَ زَهُوقًا

"Truth has come, and falsehood has departed. Indeed, falsehood is ever bound to depart."

Al-Isrāʾ 17:81. Narrated by al-Bukhārī (4287); he also recited: "Truth has come, and falsehood can neither begin nor return" (Sabaʾ 34:49).

He refused to enter the Kaʿbah until the pictures in it were removed, including images of Ibrāhīm and Ismāʿīl holding divining arrows. "May Allah fight them," he said. "By Allah, they knew that the two of them never sought omens by arrows" (al-Bukhārī, 4288). He prayed inside with Bilāl, Usāmah

and ʿUthmān ibn Ṭalḥah (al-Bukhārī, 1598), then returned the key of the Kaʿbah to ʿUthmān ibn Ṭalḥah and his family. The sīrah books report that **Bilāl**, once tortured on the sand of Makkah, climbed onto the roof of the Kaʿbah and called the adhān.

"Go, for you are free"

The people of Makkah gathered at the Kaʿbah, waiting to hear what would be done with them: the people who had mocked him, beaten his Companions, killed his relatives, driven him out and fought him for twenty years. The sīrah books report that he asked: "O people of Quraysh, what do you think I will do with you?" They said: "Good: a noble brother, and the son of a noble brother." He said: "I say to you what Yūsuf said to his brothers: **No blame will there be upon you today** (Yūsuf 12:92). Go, for you are free."

Only a handful of people, guilty of grave crimes, were excepted from the amnesty (Abū Dāwūd, 2683), and most of them were forgiven when they came seeking pardon, among them ʿIkrimah ibn Abī Jahl, Hind bint ʿUtbah and Waḥshī. The people of Makkah came in crowds to pledge allegiance, men and women (al-Mumtaḥanah 60:12). Abū Bakr brought his aged father, Abū Quḥāfah, whose hair was white, and he accepted Islām (Muslim, 2102).

إِنَّ اللَّهَ حَرَّمَ مَكَّةَ فَلَمْ تَحِلَّ لِأَحَدٍ قَبْلِي وَلَا تَحِلُّ لِأَحَدٍ بَعْدِي، وَإِنَّمَا أُحِلَّتْ لِي سَاعَةً مِنْ نَهَارٍ

"Allah has made Makkah sacred. It was not lawful for anyone before me and will not be lawful for anyone after me. It was made lawful for me only for an hour of one day."

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (1349, 4313), from his sermon the day after the Opening.

The Prophet ﷺ stayed in Makkah nineteen days, shortening his prayers (al-Bukhārī, 1080), and sent Companions to destroy the idols of the surrounding tribes: Khālid to al-ʿUzzā, ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ to Suwāʿ and Saʿd ibn Zayd to Manāt. He said: "There is no hijrah after the Opening, but jihād and intention" (al-Bukhārī, 2783).

إِذَا جَاءَ نَصْرُ اللَّهِ وَالْفَتْحُ ﴿١﴾ وَرَأَيْتَ النَّاسَ يَدْخُلُونَ فِي دِينِ اللَّهِ أَفْوَاجًا ﴿٢﴾ فَسَبِّحْ بِحَمْدِ رَبِّكَ وَاسْتَغْفِرْهُ ۚ إِنَّهُ كَانَ تَوَّابًا

"When the victory of Allah has come and the Opening, and you see the people entering the religion of Allah in multitudes, then glorify the praise of your Lord and ask His forgiveness. Indeed, He is ever Accepting of repentance."

Sūrat an-Naṣr (110). Ibn ʿAbbās understood from it that the Prophet's ﷺ time was drawing near (al-Bukhārī, 4970).

Lessons from the Opening of Makkah

1	**Victory brings humility, not pride.** He entered with his head bowed, reciting the Qur'an.
2	**Mercy in power.** The people who had persecuted him for twenty years were set free.
3	**Tawḥīd first.** His first act was to clear the idols from the House of Allah.
4	**Honour those who suffered.** Bilāl called the adhān from the Kaʿbah; the poor freed slave's son rode behind the Prophet ﷺ.
5	**After victory, glorify Allah and seek forgiveness** (an-Naṣr 110:3).

05

THE BATTLES OF THE PROPHET 05 · ﷺ

وَيَوْمَ حُنَيْنٍ

THE LAST BATTLES

Ḥunayn & Tabūk

Ḥunayn, aṭ-Ṭāʾif and the last expedition

8 – 9 AH · 630 – 631 CE · Ḥunayn, aṭ-Ṭāʾif, Tabūk

12,000	30,000	50
Muslims at Ḥunayn	marched to Tabūk	nights of Kaʿb ibn Mālik's trial

Battle 7 The Battle of Ḥunayn: at a glance

Date	Shawwāl 8 AH (January–February 630 CE), a few weeks after the Opening
Place	The valley of Ḥunayn, between Makkah and aṭ-Ṭāʾif
Muslims	About 12,000: the 10,000 of the Opening and about 2,000 newly Muslim people of Makkah
Opponents	Hawāzin and Thaqīf under Mālik ibn ʿAwf, a large force that brought its women, children and herds
Outcome	An early rout, then a complete victory. Huge spoils: about 6,000 captives and tens of thousands of camels and sheep
In the Qur'an	At-Tawbah 9:25–27

Pride in numbers

The great tribe of Hawāzin, with Thaqīf of aṭ-Ṭāʾif, gathered to strike the Muslims before they grew stronger. Their young commander, **Mālik ibn ʿAwf**, made the men bring their wives, children and herds, so that they would not flee. The Muslims marched out twelve thousand strong, the largest army they had ever had. The sīrah books report that someone said: "We will not be defeated today for lack of numbers."

On the way, some new Muslims passed a great tree on which the idolaters hung their weapons for blessing, and said: "O Messenger of Allah, make for us a Dhāt Anwāṭ like theirs." He said: "Subḥān Allāh! This is like what the people of Mūsā said: Make for us a god as they have gods. By the One in whose hand is my soul, you will follow the ways of those before you" (at-Tirmidhī, 2180).

The ambush

Hawāzin reached the valley first and hid in its slopes and passes. The Muslims entered it in the darkness before dawn. Suddenly arrows rained down from every side; Hawāzin's archers "hardly missed". The vanguard, many of them young and without armour, broke and fled, and the panic spread through the army (al-Bukhārī, 2864).

لَقَدْ نَصَرَكُمُ اللَّهُ فِي مَوَاطِنَ كَثِيرَةٍ ۙ وَيَوْمَ حُنَيْنٍ ۙ إِذْ أَعْجَبَتْكُمْ كَثْرَتُكُمْ فَلَمْ تُغْنِ عَنكُمْ شَيْئًا وَضَاقَتْ عَلَيْكُمُ الْأَرْضُ بِمَا رَحُبَتْ ثُمَّ وَلَّيْتُم مُّدْبِرِينَ

"Allah has already given you victory in many places, and on the day of Ḥunayn, when your great number pleased you, but it did not avail you at all, and the earth was confining for you despite its vastness; then you turned back, fleeing."

At-Tawbah 9:25.

The Prophet ﷺ did not move. He sat on his white mule, with his cousin Abū Sufyān ibn al-Ḥārith holding its reins, urging it towards the enemy and calling:

أَنَا النَّبِيُّ لَا كَذِبْ، أَنَا ابْنُ عَبْدِ الْمُطَّلِبْ

"I am the Prophet, that is no lie. I am the son of ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib."

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (2864) and Muslim (1776), from al-Barāʾ ibn ʿĀzib.

He told his uncle **al-ʿAbbās**, who had a powerful voice, to call out: "Where are the people of the tree?" (those who had pledged under the tree at al-Ḥudaybiyah). Al-ʿAbbās said: "By Allah, when they heard my voice, they turned back as cows turn back to their calves, saying: Here we are! Here we are!" The fighting resumed. The Prophet ﷺ looked at it and said: "Now the oven is hot." He took some pebbles and threw them in the enemy's faces, saying: "They are defeated, by the Lord of Muḥammad," and Hawāzin broke (Muslim, 1775).

ثُمَّ أَنزَلَ اللَّهُ سَكِينَتَهُ عَلَىٰ رَسُولِهِ وَعَلَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَأَنزَلَ جُنُودًا لَّمْ تَرَوْهَا وَعَذَّبَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا

"Then Allah sent down His tranquillity upon His Messenger and upon the believers, and sent down soldiers you did not see, and punished those who disbelieved."

At-Tawbah 9:26.

Umm Sulaym fought at Ḥunayn with a dagger in her belt, saying she would rip open any idolater who came near her (Muslim, 1809). When the Prophet ﷺ saw a woman who had been killed, he sent word to Khālid: "Do not kill a woman or a hired labourer" (Abū Dāwūd, 2669). Part of the enemy regrouped at **Awṭās** and was defeated there; Abū ʿĀmir al-Ashʿarī, the commander, was martyred, and the Prophet ﷺ raised his hands and prayed for him (al-Bukhārī, 4323).

Battle 8 The siege of aṭ-Ṭāʾif

Mālik ibn ʿAwf fled with Thaqīf to **aṭ-Ṭāʾif**, a walled city with strong forts and a year's supplies. The Muslims besieged it, the reports say for between about twenty and forty nights, and used a catapult for the first time. The Prophet ﷺ announced that any slave who came down from the city would be free, and some did, among them Abū Bakrah, who let himself down by a pulley (bakrah), which gave him his name (al-Bukhārī, 4326). Many Muslims were struck by arrows from the walls.

The Prophet ﷺ said: "We will leave tomorrow, if Allah wills." The Companions were unhappy and wanted to fight on, so he said: "Fight in the morning." They fought and were wounded. Then he said again: "We will leave tomorrow," and this time they were pleased, and the Prophet ﷺ smiled (al-Bukhārī, 4325). When they asked him to curse Thaqīf, he said instead: "**O Allah, guide Thaqīf**" (at-Tirmidhī, 3942).

Eleven years earlier, the people of aṭ-Ṭāʾif had stoned him out of their city. The angel of the mountains had offered to crush them between two mountains, and he had said: "Rather, I hope that Allah will bring from their descendants people who worship Allah alone" (al-Bukhārī, 3231). Within a year of the siege, in Ramaḍān 9 AH, Thaqīf sent a delegation to Madinah and accepted Islām, and their idol al-Lāt was pulled down.

The spoils of Ḥunayn and the Anṣār

The captives and spoils of Ḥunayn were gathered at al-Jiʿrānah. The Prophet ﷺ waited more than ten days for Hawāzin to come; when they came as Muslims, asking for their families back, he and the Muslims returned all the captives (al-Bukhārī 2307–2308). He gave generously from the rest to the leaders of Quraysh and the tribes who had only just entered Islām, "those whose hearts are to be reconciled" (at-Tawbah 9:60). He gave Ṣafwān ibn Umayyah a whole valley of sheep. Ṣafwān said: "He gave to me when he was the most hateful of people to me, and he kept giving until he became the most beloved of people to me" (Muslim, 2313).

When a man said, "This division was not made for the sake of Allah," the Prophet ﷺ said: "May Allah have mercy on Mūsā. He was harmed with more than this, and he was patient" (al-Bukhārī, 3150). The Anṣār, who received nothing, felt hurt, and some young men among them said: "He gives to Quraysh and leaves us, while our swords still drip with their blood." The Prophet ﷺ gathered them alone in a tent and said:

> يَا مَعْشَرَ الْأَنْصَارِ، أَلَمْ أَجِدْكُمْ ضُلَّالًا فَهَدَاكُمُ اللَّهُ بِي، وَكُنْتُمْ مُتَفَرِّقِينَ فَأَلَّفَكُمُ اللَّهُ بِي، وَعَالَةً فَأَغْنَاكُمُ اللَّهُ بِي
>
> **"O Anṣār, did I not find you astray, and Allah guided you through me? Divided, and Allah united you through me? Poor, and Allah enriched you through me?"**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (4330) and Muslim (1061).

To each sentence they answered: “Allah and His Messenger are more gracious.” He said: “Are you not pleased that the people go away with sheep and camels, while you go back to your homes with the Messenger of Allah? Were it not for the Hijrah, I would have been one of the Anṣār. If the people went through a valley and the Anṣār through a mountain pass, I would go through the pass of the Anṣār” (al-Bukhārī, 4330). The sīrah books say they wept until their beards were wet, and said: “We are pleased with the Messenger of Allah as our share.” The Prophet ﷺ then made ʿumrah from al-Jiʿrānah and returned to Madinah.

Expedition 9 Tabūk: the expedition of hardship

Date	Rajab 9 AH (October 630 CE), the last ghazwah
Place	Tabūk, about 700 km north of Madinah, near the Byzantine border
Muslims	The sīrah books say about 30,000, the largest army of his life
Reason	News that the Byzantines and their Arab allies were gathering to attack
Outcome	No battle. The enemy did not come out; treaties were made with the towns of the border. The hypocrites were exposed
In the Qur'an	Much of Sūrat at-Tawbah (9), from verse 38 onwards

A call in the heat

Kaʿb ibn Mālik said that the Prophet ﷺ usually kept the destination of an expedition hidden, but this time he announced it clearly, because the journey was long, through desert, in extreme heat, against a great enemy, so that people could prepare properly (al-Bukhārī, 4418). It was the season when the fruit was ripe and the shade was most tempting. It was called **Jaysh al-ʿUsrah**, "the army of hardship".

Those who gave

The Prophet ﷺ urged the Muslims to spend. **ʿUthmān** equipped a large part of the army; when he brought a thousand dinars and poured them into the Prophet's ﷺ lap, the Prophet ﷺ turned them over in his hand and said twice: "Nothing ʿUthmān does after today will harm him" (at-Tirmidhī, 3701). It is reported that **ʿUmar** brought half of his wealth, thinking he would outdo Abū Bakr this time, and **Abū Bakr** brought everything he had. "What have you left for your family?" "I have left them Allah and His Messenger" (at-Tirmidhī, 3675). The poor gave what little they had, and the hypocrites mocked them (at-Tawbah 9:79).

Some poor Companions came asking for mounts. The Prophet ﷺ had none to give, and they went away weeping, sad that they could not go. Allah honoured them in the Qur'an: "they turned back while their eyes overflowed with tears out of grief that they could not find something to spend" (at-Tawbah 9:92).

Those who stayed behind

The hypocrites made excuses: "Do not go out in the heat." Allah answered: "Say: The fire of Hell is more intense in heat, if they would but understand" (9:81). One said: "Permit me to stay, and do not tempt me" (with the women of Rome); Allah said: "Unquestionably, into temptation they have fallen" (9:49). The Prophet ﷺ left **ʿAlī** in charge of his family in Madinah. When ʿAlī said: "Are you leaving me with the women and children?" he replied: "Are you not pleased to be to me as Hārūn was to Mūsā, except that there is no prophet after me?" (al-Bukhārī, 4416).

The journey

On the way the army passed **al-Ḥijr**, the ruined dwellings of Thamūd. The Prophet ﷺ covered his face, hurried his camel and said: “Do not enter the dwellings of those who wronged themselves except weeping, lest what befell them befall you” (al-Bukhārī, 4419). He told them not to drink from its wells and to feed the dough they had made with its water to their camels (al-Bukhārī, 3378).

At Tabūk they found no army: the Byzantines had not come out. The Prophet ﷺ stayed about twenty days, shortening the prayer (Abū Dāwūd, 1235). The ruler of **Aylah** came and made peace, and presented him with a white mule; the Prophet ﷺ gave him a cloak and wrote him a guarantee of protection (al-Bukhārī, 1481). The towns of Adhruḥ, Jarbāʾ and Maqnā also made treaties, and Khālid was sent to Ukaydir, the ruler of Dūmat al-Jandal, who was brought to Madinah and made peace (Abū Dāwūd, 3037). Without a single battle, the northern border of Arabia was secured.

On the way home, near Madinah, the Prophet ﷺ said: “In Madinah there are people who were with you in every journey you travelled and every valley you crossed.” They said: “While they are in Madinah?” He said: “While they are in Madinah. Their excuses held them back” (al-Bukhārī, 4423). On his return, a mosque built by the hypocrites to divide the believers, **Masjid aḍ-Ḍirār**, was pulled down (at-Tawbah 9:107–110).

Kaʿb ibn Mālik: the three who stayed behind

Kaʿb ibn Mālik, a poet and a Companion of the Pledge of al-ʿAqabah, had never been stronger or wealthier than at the time of Tabūk. He kept telling himself he would prepare tomorrow, until the army had gone too far to catch. When the Prophet ﷺ returned, more than eighty men came with excuses and swore oaths, and he accepted what they showed and left their hearts to Allah. Kaʿb came and told the truth: “By Allah, I had no excuse.” The Prophet ﷺ said: “As for this one, he has told the truth. Go, until Allah decides about you.” Two others, **Murārah ibn ar-Rabīʿ** and **Hilāl ibn Umayyah**, also told the truth (al-Bukhārī, 4418).

The Prophet ﷺ told the Muslims not to speak to the three. For **fifty nights**, no one returned their greeting. “The earth itself changed for me,” Kaʿb said. A letter came from the Christian king of Ghassān inviting him to join him; Kaʿb said: “This too is a trial,” and threw it into an oven. After forty nights they were told to keep away from their wives. Then, on the fiftieth morning, as Kaʿb sat after Fajr on the roof of his house, “the earth confining for me despite its vastness”, he heard a voice from the mountain of Salʿ: “O Kaʿb ibn Mālik, receive glad tidings!” Allah had accepted their repentance:

وَعَلَى الثَّلَاثَةِ الَّذِينَ خُلِّفُوا حَتَّىٰ إِذَا ضَاقَتْ عَلَيْهِمُ الْأَرْضُ بِمَا رَحُبَتْ وَضَاقَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ أَنفُسُهُمْ وَظَنُّوا أَن لَّا مَلْجَأَ مِنَ اللَّهِ إِلَّا إِلَيْهِ ثُمَّ تَابَ عَلَيْهِمْ لِيَتُوبُوا

"And [He also forgave] the three who were left behind, until the earth, vast as it is, became confining for them, and their souls confined them, and they were certain that there is no refuge from Allah except in Him. Then He turned to them so they could repent."

At-Tawbah 9:118, followed by: "O you who believe, fear Allah and be with those who are truthful" (9:119).

Kaʿb went to the Prophet ﷺ, whose face was shining with joy, and he said: "Receive glad tidings of the best day you have had since your mother bore you." Kaʿb said: "O Messenger of Allah, Allah saved me only because of truthfulness, and part of my repentance is that I will speak nothing but the truth for as long as I live" (al-Bukhārī, 4418).

Lessons from Ḥunayn, aṭ-Ṭāʾif and Tabūk

1	**Numbers do not bring victory; Allah does.** Twelve thousand fled; a few hundred around the Prophet ﷺ turned the day.
2	**Courage in leadership.** When everyone ran, the Prophet ﷺ rode towards the enemy calling his name.
3	**Pray for people's guidance, not their destruction**: "O Allah, guide Thaqīf."
4	**Love of the Prophet ﷺ is worth more than wealth**, as the Anṣār learned at al-Jiʿrānah.
5	**Do not delay good deeds.** Kaʿb lost Tabūk by saying "tomorrow".
6	**Truthfulness saves.** The liars were excused for a moment; the truthful were forgiven forever.

After Tabūk — The end of the maghāzī

Tabūk was the last expedition of the Prophet ﷺ. In the months that followed, called the **Year of Delegations**, tribe after tribe from every corner of Arabia sent delegations to Madinah to accept Islām. In 9 AH, Abū Bakr led the Ḥajj and the opening verses of Sūrat at-Tawbah were proclaimed: no idolater would perform Ḥajj after that year, and no one would circle the Kaʿbah naked (al-Bukhārī,

369). In 10 AH, the Prophet ﷺ performed the **Farewell Ḥajj** with more than a hundred thousand Muslims.

In his last days, the Prophet ﷺ prepared an army under the young **Usāmah ibn Zayd**, whose father Zayd had been martyred at Muʾtah, to go to the borders of Shām. Some objected to his youth; the Prophet ﷺ said he was fit to lead, as his father had been (al-Bukhārī, 4469). The Prophet ﷺ passed away in Rabīʿ al-Awwal 11 AH before the army left, and Abū Bakr sent it out as one of his first acts as caliph.

Part 7 All the battles at a glance

The 27 ghazawāt, in order

No.	Expedition	Date (AH)	Result
1	Waddān (al-Abwāʾ)	Ṣafar 2	Treaty with Banū Ḍamrah
2	Buwāṭ	Rabīʿ al-Awwal 2	Quraysh caravan not met
3	al-ʿUshayrah	Jumādā 2	Treaty with Banū Mudlij
4	Badr al-Ūlā (Safawān)	Rabīʿ al-Awwal 2	Pursuit of Kurz ibn Jābir
5	**Badr al-Kubrā**	17 Ramaḍān 2	**Great victory**
6	Banū Sulaym (al-Kudr)	Shawwāl 2	The enemy scattered
7	as-Sawīq	Dhul-Ḥijjah 2	Abū Sufyān fled
8	Dhū Amarr (Ghaṭafān)	Rabīʿ al-Awwal 3	The enemy scattered
9	Buḥrān	Jumādā 3	No fighting
10	**Uḥud**	Shawwāl 3	**About 70 martyrs**
11	Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad	Shawwāl 3	Quraysh hurried home
12	Banū an-Naḍīr	Rabīʿ al-Awwal 4	Siege; they left Madinah
13	Dhāt ar-Riqāʿ	4 (or 7)	The prayer of fear
14	Badr al-Ākhirah	Shaʿbān 4	Quraysh did not come
15	Dūmat al-Jandal	Rabīʿ al-Awwal 5	The enemy scattered
16	**al-Khandaq**	Shawwāl 5	**The confederates withdrew**
17	**Banū Qurayẓah**	Dhul-Qaʿdah 5	**Siege and judgement**
18	Banū Liḥyān	6	They fled
19	Dhū Qarad (al-Ghābah)	6 (or 7)	Camels recovered
20	**Banū al-Muṣṭaliq**	Shaʿbān 5 (or 6)	**Victory at al-Muraysīʿ**
21	al-Ḥudaybiyah	Dhul-Qaʿdah 6	Treaty; Pledge of Riḍwān
22	**Khaybar**	Muḥarram 7	**Forts opened**
23	ʿUmrat al-Qaḍāʾ	Dhul-Qaʿdah 7	The ʿumrah performed
24	**The Opening of Makkah**	Ramaḍān 8	**Makkah opened; amnesty**
25	**Ḥunayn**	Shawwāl 8	**Victory after a rout**
26	**aṭ-Ṭāʾif**	Shawwāl 8	**Siege lifted; Thaqīf later Muslim**
27	Tabūk	Rajab 9	No battle; treaties

This is the list given by Ibn Isḥāq (through Ibn Hishām), with the expeditions in which fighting took place in bold. Some scholars count the siege of Banū Qaynuqāʿ separately, or join others together, so lists differ slightly.

Some of the major sarāyā

Sariyyah	Year	Commander	What happened
Sīf al-Baḥr	1 AH	Ḥamzah ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib	The first banner of Islām; no fighting
Nakhlah	2 AH	ʿAbdullāh ibn Jaḥsh	A caravan attacked in the sacred month (al-Baqarah 2:217)
al-Qaradah	3 AH	Zayd ibn Ḥārithah	A Quraysh caravan on the Iraq route captured
ar-Rajīʿ	4 AH	ʿĀṣim ibn Thābit	Ten Companions betrayed; Khubayb martyred in Makkah
Biʾr Maʿūnah	4 AH	al-Mundhir ibn ʿAmr	Seventy reciters betrayed and martyred
Muʾtah	8 AH	Zayd, Jaʿfar, Ibn Rawāḥah, then Khālid	Against Byzantium; three commanders martyred
Dhāt as-Salāsil	8 AH	ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ	Tribes on the Shām border dispersed
Sīf al-Baḥr (al-Khabaṭ)	8 AH	Abū ʿUbaydah ibn al-Jarrāḥ	Hunger, and the great fish thrown up by the sea
Usāmah's army	11 AH	Usāmah ibn Zayd	Prepared by the Prophet ﷺ, sent by Abū Bakr

The major battles compared

Battle	Muslims	Opponents	Muslim martyrs	Opponents killed
Badr (2 AH)	313	about 1,000	14	70 (and 70 captured)
Uḥud (3 AH)	about 700	about 3,000	about 70	about 22
The Trench (5 AH)	about 3,000	about 10,000	about 6	a few
Khaybar (7 AH)	about 1,400–1,600	several thousand	about 16–20	about 90
Muʾtah (8 AH)	3,000	far greater	about 12	unknown
Makkah (8 AH)	10,000	little resistance	2	about 12
Ḥunayn (8 AH)	12,000	a very large force	a few	many; 6,000 captured
Tabūk (9 AH)	about 30,000	did not come out	none	none

Numbers are approximate and mostly from the books of sīrah; the reports differ.

The battles in the Qur'an

Event	Where to read it
The permission to fight	Al-Ḥajj 22:39–40; al-Baqarah 2:190–193
Nakhlah	Al-Baqarah 2:217

Badr	Sūrat al-Anfāl (8); Āl ʿImrān 3:12–13, 3:123–127
Uḥud and Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad	Āl ʿImrān 3:121–179
Banū an-Naḍīr	Sūrat al-Ḥashr (59)
The prayer of fear	An-Nisāʾ 4:101–103
Banū al-Muṣṭaliq and the slander	Sūrat al-Munāfiqūn (63); an-Nūr 24:11–26
The Trench and Banū Qurayẓah	Al-Aḥzāb 33:9–27
Al-Ḥudaybiyah and Khaybar	Sūrat al-Fatḥ (48)
The Opening of Makkah	Al-Mumtaḥanah 60:1; al-Ḥadīd 57:10; an-Naṣr (110)
Ḥunayn	At-Tawbah 9:25–27
Tabūk and the three who stayed behind	At-Tawbah 9:38–129

Part 8 The heroes of the battles

Behind every battle are men and women whose faith and courage the Ummah still remembers. Here are some of them.

The women of the battles

Women took part in the maghāzī by carrying water, treating the wounded and, when needed, defending themselves and the Prophet ﷺ. Ar-Rubayyiʿ bint Muʿawwidh said: "We used to go out with the Prophet ﷺ to give water to the people, serve them, and bring the dead and wounded back to Madinah" (al-Bukhārī, 2882). Anas saw ʿĀʾishah and Umm Sulaym at Uḥud carrying water skins on their backs and pouring water into the mouths of the wounded (al-Bukhārī, 2880).

Hero	Why we remember them
Ḥamzah ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib	The Prophet's ﷺ uncle and foster-brother, the Lion of Allah. He fought in single combat at Badr and was martyred at Uḥud. The Prophet ﷺ called him the master of the martyrs (al-Ḥākim).
ʿAlī ibn Abī Ṭālib	Fought at Badr, held firm at Uḥud, met ʿAmr ibn ʿAbd Wudd at the Trench, and carried the flag at Khaybar, where Allah gave victory at his hands.
Saʿd ibn Muʿādh	Chief of the Aws. He pledged the Anṣār's loyalty before Badr, was wounded at the Trench, judged Banū Qurayẓah, and at his death the Throne of the Most Merciful shook.
Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr	The first teacher sent to Madinah. He carried the standard at Uḥud until he was killed, and was buried in a cloak too short to cover him.
Ṭalḥah ibn ʿUbaydillāh	Shielded the Prophet ﷺ at Uḥud until his hand was paralysed. The Prophet ﷺ said that day that Paradise was due to him (at-Tirmidhī, 1692).
Anas ibn an-Naḍr	Missed Badr and vowed Allah would see what he would do. At Uḥud he smelled the fragrance of Paradise and fell with more than eighty wounds.
Jaʿfar ibn Abī Ṭālib	Leader of the emigrants to Abyssinia. Martyred at Muʾtah with more than ninety wounds, all in front; given two wings in Paradise.
Khālid ibn al-Walīd	Turned the tide against the Muslims at Uḥud before his Islām, then saved the Muslim army at Muʾtah, and was named the Sword of Allah.
Salamah ibn al-Akwaʿ	A young runner who, on foot and alone, chased the raiders at Dhū Qarad and recovered the camels. "The best of our foot soldiers."
Nusaybah bint Kaʿb (Umm ʿUmārah)	An Anṣārī woman who, the sīrah books tell, fought to defend the Prophet ﷺ at Uḥud and was wounded many times.
Umm Sulaym bint Milḥān	Carried water for the wounded at Uḥud with ʿĀʾishah (al-Bukhārī, 2880) and carried a dagger at Ḥunayn (Muslim, 1809).
Ṣafiyyah bint ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib	Ḥamzah's sister. The sīrah books tell how, during the Trench, she guarded the fort where the women sheltered against a man of Banū Qurayẓah.

Part 9 Jihād rightly understood

The battles of the Prophet ﷺ are sometimes misused: by enemies of Islām, to claim it was spread by the sword, and by extremists, to justify violence against innocent people. A Muslim who knows the sīrah can answer both.

What the battles show

- **Islām was not spread by force.** For thirteen years the Muslims did not fight at all. After the Hijrah, the Prophet ﷺ fought those who fought him, expelled him or broke their treaties. Most of Arabia entered Islām in the years of peace after al-Ḥudaybiyah and the Opening, not on the battlefield. "There is no compulsion in religion" (al-Baqarah 2:256).
- **War had strict rules.** No killing of women, children, the elderly, monks, labourers or envoys; no mutilation, betrayal or needless destruction; prisoners fed and freed. These rules came centuries before any modern convention.
- **Treaties were sacred.** The Prophet ﷺ returned Abū Jandal in chains rather than break his word, and turned Ḥudhayfah away from Badr because of a promise.
- **Mercy outweighed revenge.** At the Opening of Makkah he forgave the people who had fought him for twenty years. At aṭ-Ṭāʾif he prayed for the guidance of those who had stoned him.

The wider meaning of jihād

Jihād means striving. Fighting is one form of it, with its own conditions; but the Prophet ﷺ also taught that:

- "The mujāhid is the one who strives against himself in obedience to Allah" (at-Tirmidhī 1621; Aḥmad).
- "The best jihād is a word of truth before a tyrant ruler" (Abū Dāwūd 4344, at-Tirmidhī 2174).
- A young man asked to join the jihād. The Prophet ﷺ asked: "Are your parents alive?" He said yes. "Then strive in serving them" (al-Bukhārī 3004, Muslim 2549).
- ʿĀʾishah asked: "We see jihād as the best of deeds; should we not fight?" He said: "For you women, the best jihād is an accepted Ḥajj" (al-Bukhārī, 1520).

What the battles do not allow

- **Individuals and groups do not declare war.** In Islamic law, fighting is declared and led by the legitimate Muslim authority, as the Prophet ﷺ led it in his time, and not by individuals or secret groups.
- **Killing innocent people is among the gravest sins.** "Whoever kills a soul… it is as if he had slain mankind entirely" (al-Māʾidah 5:32). "Whoever kills a muʿāhad will not smell the fragrance of Paradise" (al-Bukhārī 3166). Non-Muslims living in peace, in Muslim lands or elsewhere, are under this protection.
- **Suicide is forbidden** (an-Nisāʾ 4:29), and so is betrayal of a promise of safety, which includes visas and citizenship.
- **Allah does not forbid kindness and justice** to those who do not fight us or drive us out of our homes (al-Mumtaḥanah 60:8).

Scholars across the Ummah have condemned terrorism in the name of Islām as a betrayal of the Prophet's ﷺ own example. Learn these matters from qualified, trustworthy scholars, not from the internet.

Duʿāʾs Duʿāʾs from the battlefield

These are duʿāʾs the Prophet ﷺ and the believers made in the battles. They are for every hardship, not only war. Memorise them and use them in your own life.

Badr

اللَّهُمَّ أَنْجِزْ لِي مَا وَعَدْتَنِي، اللَّهُمَّ آتِ مَا وَعَدْتَنِي

“O Allah, fulfil for me what You promised me. O Allah, give me what You promised me.”

Muslim (1763).

Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad

حَسْبُنَا اللَّهُ وَنِعْمَ الْوَكِيلُ

“Allah is sufficient for us, and He is the best Disposer of affairs.”

Āl ʿImrān 3:173; al-Bukhārī (4563).

The Trench

اللَّهُمَّ مُنْزِلَ الْكِتَابِ، سَرِيعَ الْحِسَابِ، اهْزِمِ الْأَحْزَابَ، اللَّهُمَّ اهْزِمْهُمْ وَزَلْزِلْهُمْ

“O Allah, Revealer of the Book, Swift in reckoning, defeat the confederates. O Allah, defeat them and shake them.”

Al-Bukhārī (2933), Muslim (1742).

Digging the trench

اللَّهُمَّ لَا عَيْشَ إِلَّا عَيْشُ الْآخِرَهْ، فَاغْفِرْ لِلْأَنْصَارِ وَالْمُهَاجِرَهْ

“O Allah, there is no life except the life of the Hereafter, so forgive the Anṣār and the Muhājirah.”

Al-Bukhārī (2834).

Facing an enemy

اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّا نَجْعَلُكَ فِي نُحُورِهِمْ، وَنَعُوذُ بِكَ مِنْ شُرُورِهِمْ

“O Allah, we place You before them, and we seek refuge in You from their evil.”

Said by the Prophet ﷺ when he feared a people; Abū Dāwūd (1537).

Firmness

رَبَّنَا أَفْرِغْ عَلَيْنَا صَبْرًا وَثَبِّتْ أَقْدَامَنَا وَانصُرْنَا عَلَى الْقَوْمِ الْكَافِرِينَ

“Our Lord, pour upon us patience, plant firmly our feet and give us victory over the disbelieving people.”

The duʿāʾ of the believers with Ṭālūt, whose number matched the people of Badr; al-Baqarah 2:250.

Part 10 Lessons for today

What the maghāzī teach us

1	**Patience before power.** Thirteen years of patience came before the first battle. Do not rush what Allah has timed.
2	**Take the means, then rely on Allah.** Wells at Badr, archers at Uḥud, a trench at the Trench: planning is part of tawakkul.
3	**Obey Allah and His Messenger ﷺ, especially when it is hard.** Uḥud was lost by disobedience; al-Ḥudaybiyah was won by obedience the Companions did not understand at the time.
4	**Consult and listen.** The Prophet ﷺ consulted at every major step, and took advice from al-Ḥubāb, Salmān and Umm Salamah.
5	**Victory belongs to Allah.** Badr with 313, the Trench with a wind, Ḥunayn after the rout of 12,000.
6	**Be just and merciful, even to enemies.** The rules of war, the treatment of prisoners and the pardon of Makkah.
7	**Stay truthful.** Kaʿb ibn Mālik's honesty saved him; the hypocrites' excuses ruined them.
8	**Spend and sacrifice.** ʿUthmān, Abū Bakr and the poor Companions who gave a handful of dates are still remembered.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers are at the end of the test.

1. Which verse was the first permission to fight?

a) Al-Baqarah 2:255 b) Al-Ḥajj 22:39 c) At-Tawbah 9:5 d) Al-Kawthar 108:1

2. A ghazwah is an expedition in which:

a) There was no fighting b) Only the Anṣār took part c) The Prophet ﷺ went out himself d) A treaty was signed

3. About how many Muslims fought at Badr?

a) 313 b) 700 c) 1,400 d) 3,000

4. Who killed Abū Jahl at Badr?

a) Ḥamzah and ʿAlī b) Two young Anṣārī boys named Muʿādh c) Khālid ibn al-Walīd d) ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb

5. Why did the Muslims suffer at Uḥud?

a) They had too few horses b) It rained on them c) The hypocrites attacked them d) Most of the archers left their post

6. Who killed Ḥamzah at Uḥud?

a) Abū Sufyān b) Khālid ibn al-Walīd c) Waḥshī d) ʿIkrimah

7. Which sūrah was revealed about Banū an-Naḍīr?

a) Al-Ḥashr b) Al-Kahf c) Yā Sīn d) Al-Mulk

8. Whose idea was the trench, according to the sīrah books?

a) Abū Bakr b) Saʿd ibn Muʿādh c) Ḥudhayfah d) Salmān al-Fārisī

9. What scattered the confederates at the Trench?

a) A flood b) A cold wind and unseen hosts c) An attack from Khaybar d) A plague

10. Allah called the Treaty of al-Ḥudaybiyah:

a) A clear victory b) A great loss c) A test of wealth d) A broken promise

11. To whom did the Prophet ﷺ give the flag at Khaybar?

a) Abū Bakr b) ʿUmar c) ʿAlī d) Zayd

12. Who was named "the Sword of Allah" after Muʾtah?

a) Jaʿfar b) Khālid ibn al-Walīd c) Zayd ibn Ḥārithah d) Abū ʿUbaydah

13. How many idols stood around the Kaʿbah at the Opening of Makkah?

a) 99 b) 313 c) 360 d) 1,000

14. What was the Muslims' mistake at Ḥunayn, according to at-Tawbah 9:25?

a) Their large number pleased them b) They came too late c) They had no archers d) They broke a treaty

15. For how many nights were Kaʿb ibn Mālik and his two companions boycotted?

a) 7 b) 50 c) 30 d) 100

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Al-Ḥajj 22:39	9	b) Wind and unseen hosts
2	c) He went out himself	10	a) A clear victory
3	a) 313	11	c) ʿAlī
4	b) The two Muʿādhs	12	b) Khālid ibn al-Walīd
5	d) The archers left	13	c) 360
6	c) Waḥshī	14	a) Their number pleased them
7	a) Al-Ḥashr	15	b) 50
8	d) Salmān al-Fārisī		

Activities

1 **Which battle moved you most, and what is one lesson from it you can act on this week?**

.....

.....

.....

2 **Choose one hero from Part 8. Write three sentences about them in your own words.**

.....

.....

.....

3 **Find the verses about one battle in your muṣḥaf and read them with a translation. What did you notice?**

.....

.....

.....

Glossary Words to know

Term	Meaning
Maghāzī	The expeditions of the Prophet ﷺ, and the field of study that records them.
Ghazwah / Sariyyah	An expedition led by the Prophet ﷺ himself / one he sent under a Companion.
Muhājirūn	The emigrants from Makkah to Madinah.
Anṣār	The Muslims of Madinah, the Aws and Khazraj, who sheltered the Prophet ﷺ.
Munāfiqūn	Hypocrites: those who showed Islām but hid disbelief.
Al-Aḥzāb	The confederates: the allied tribes who besieged Madinah at the Trench.
ʿArīsh	The shelter built for the Prophet ﷺ overlooking the field of Badr.
Ṣalāt al-khawf	The prayer of fear, prayed in groups while facing an enemy (an-Nisāʾ 4:102).
Bayʿat ar-Riḍwān	The Pledge of Good Pleasure under the tree at al-Ḥudaybiyah (al-Fatḥ 48:18).
Al-Fatḥ	The Opening: used for al-Ḥudaybiyah (48:1) and for the Opening of Makkah.
Aṭ-Ṭulaqāʾ	Those freed at the Opening of Makkah: "Go, for you are free."
Al-muʾallafah qulūbuhum	Those whose hearts are to be reconciled, given a share of zakāh and spoils (at-Tawbah 9:60).
Ghulūl	Stealing from the spoils before they are divided; a grave sin.
Jizyah	A tax paid by non-Muslim subjects under Muslim protection, in place of military service.

For further reading

- **Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī**, Book of Maghāzī (Kitāb al-Maghāzī), and **Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim**, Book of Jihād and Expeditions.
- **As-Sīrah an-Nabawiyyah** of Ibn Hishām, from Ibn Isḥāq, the oldest complete sīrah.
- **Zād al-Maʿād** of Ibn al-Qayyim, the volume on the maghāzī and their lessons.
- **Ar-Raḥīq al-Makhtūm** (The Sealed Nectar) of Ṣafiyyur-Raḥmān al-Mubārakpūrī, a clear modern sīrah in English.
- Sūrat al-Anfāl, Āl ʿImrān 3:121–179, Sūrat al-Aḥzāb, Sūrat al-Fatḥ and Sūrat at-Tawbah, each with a good tafsīr.

Duʿāʾ The duʿāʾ of the believers

رَبَّنَا اغْفِرْ لَنَا ذُنُوبَنَا وَإِسْرَافَنَا فِي أَمْرِنَا وَثَبِّتْ
أَقْدَامَنَا وَانصُرْنَا عَلَى الْقَوْمِ الْكَافِرِينَ

“Our Lord, forgive us our sins and our excess in our affairs, plant firmly our feet and give us victory over the disbelieving people.”

Āl ʿImrān 3:147, revealed in the passage about Uḥud, of the believers who fought with the prophets before.

Learn sīrah with the Himaayah Madrasah

Sīrah, ḥadīth, fiqh, tawḥīd and Arabiyyah, taught step by step by teachers who know each student, live, five classes a week.

Find your level: himaayahschools.com/placement · **Enrol:** himaayahschools.com/enroll

Madrasah line (WhatsApp): +234 702 584 2849

This book is free to print and share. © Himaayah Schools, 2026.

Ten years that changed the world.

This free book from the Himaayah Madrasah tells the story of the battles and expeditions of the Prophet ﷺ, as the Qur'an, the authentic ḥadīth and the books of sīrah report them.

- Why the Prophet ﷺ fought, and the rules he set for war
- Every major battle in depth: causes, numbers, events and outcome
- Maps and battle plans of Badr, Uḥud and the Trench
- The heroes, men and women, and the verses revealed about each battle
- All 27 ghazawāt in one table, lessons for today and a self-test

Learn sīrah with the Himaayah Madrasah

Sīrah, ḥadīth, fiqh, tawḥīd and Arabiyyah, taught live by teachers who know each student, five classes a week.

himaayahschools.com/madrasah

Himaayah Schools

himaayahschools.com · WhatsApp +234 704 722 6487